



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Monday, 14th July, 2025

The House met at 2.23 p.m.

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I would plead with you to skip the item numbered 2. But, today being the first day of the week, I would crave your indulgence to rise and recite the National Pledge.

[NATIONAL PLEDGE]

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly come with me to the item numbered 6 — Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*. We would start with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Saturday, 12th July, 2025.

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Hon Members, in the absence of any corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Saturday, 12th July, 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Leadership?

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan (Deputy Majority Leader): Mr Speaker, I want to crave your indulgence to vary the order of Business on the Order Paper. That is to move to Commencement of Public Business to take the Presentation of Papers.

Mr Speaker, the first item numbered 8(c) was to be done by the Minister for Health. However, the Minister is not here at the moment, but we have the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs who himself will be laying some Papers. So, I pray that you allow him to do it on behalf of the Minister for Health, including the ones that he would do himself.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Minority Leader?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Deputy Majority Leader has just mounted an application for us to vary the order of Business. He should be patient and wait for us to first consider that application, before he jumps into making another application that a Minister should lay a Paper. His first application has not yet been granted, and he is in a hurry to make another application. But there is no problem, we will compromise for him to vary the order of Business for Papers to be laid. He knows his Ministers are not in the House. So, he is trying to be smart.

We will understand that, Mr Speaker. We can proceed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, which one are you taking?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we will look at the item numbered 8 (c).

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member is right, but I was not in a hurry. I just wanted to prompt the House that the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is in the House to do that on behalf of the Minister for Health.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, can he tell us the whereabouts of the Minister for Health because he is punctual and often in the House? As for my good friend, Hon Ahmed, laying the Paper, I have no objection. In fact, he can lay all the Papers; I have no objection. He should tell us where the Minister for Health is. Mr Speaker, he owes this House a duty to tell us where the Minister for Health is.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I am happy he said that the Minister for Health is usually in the House. But today, obviously, he is accompanying His Excellency the President, on some tour around his Constituency and other places.

That is why he is not here.

2.33 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before I allow the Minister to lay the Papers, kindly indulge me to introduce to you at the Speaker's Gallery at my right-hand side, Hon Members of

Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries Committee of the Senate and the House of Representatives of the Parliament of the Republic of Liberia. They are here to visit and to interact with us on a fact-finding mission. Their names are: Senator Wellington Geevon Smith, he is the Chairman of the Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries Committee of the Senate; the second is Hon Anthony F. Williams, he is the Chairman of the Fisheries Committee of the House of Representatives; the third is Hon Emmanuel Dahn, who is a member of the House of Representatives. They are accompanied by Prof Benjamin Campion, who is the Executive Director of the Fisheries Commission of Ghana.

Hon Members, you are welcome and we wish you a fruitful stay in Ghana.

Again, at the Public Gallery, we have our children and students, who have come to also witness their representatives here in the Parliament House.

The first school is Mpraeso Senior High School, Youth Leadership Parliament. They are being led by Mr Michael Ofose Boateng, who is the Head of Department, General Arts. The school is located at the Mpraeso Constituency and their number is about 60. Mpraeso, your Member of Parliament, is here; I hope he will take care of you after the session. *[Laughter]*

[Students from Mpraeso Senior High School were acknowledged]

The second school is Pong Tamale Senior High School and they are being

led by Mr Azong Adams, who is the Assistant Headmaster. The school is located at Savelugu Constituency and they are 32 in number.

Do you have your Member here?

Yes, Hajia Abdul Aziz; that is your Member of Parliament and as I said earlier, she is also going to take good care of you.

You are welcome.

[Students from Pong Tamale Senior High School were acknowledged]

The third school is my own school; Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST) Student Parliament. They are led by Appiah Kyei Patrick who is the Speaker of the KNUST Student Parliament. The school is located in the Oforikrom Constituency. They are 50 in number.

I think the Member is not yet in. I hope that he comes and when he comes, I will urge him to also take good care of you even though you are mature people. But I am hoping he will come.

[Students from KNUST Student Parliament were acknowledged]

The last school is Builsa Foek Festival Travel and Tour. They are led by Mr Mark Ampanfiik Daatusidi; I hope I pronounced it well. He is the President of Builsa Foek Festival Travel and Tour. They are located in the Builsa North and South Constituency and are 15 in

number. Is Mr James Agalga here? Mr Clement Apaak is also not here.

All right, I hope they will also come. But you are mature people; you do not need to be taken care of.

[Members of Builsa Foek Festival Travel and Tour were acknowledged]

All of you are welcome. I hope the students monitor what goes on here and I would urge them to study and study hard, so that tomorrow, if we are not here, they would come and take over from us.

We wish you well and we wish you a fruitful visit.

Thank you very much.

So now let me come to the item numbered 8. I hope the application is granted. Minority?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, as cooperative as we have always been —*[Laughter]*— is granted.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So which one are we taking first?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we are looking at the item numbered 8(c) first.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, can you do us the honours?

PAPER

By the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs on behalf of the Minister for Health—

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Food and Drug Authority for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Health

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, can we move to the item numbered 8(d)(i) for the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: If the Deputy Leader's intention is to ensure that we take the item numbered 8(d)(i) to (xiv) then I will pray him to seek your leave so that we can take them as a whole. So, that the Minister can do them together instead of doing them individually.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Very well, Mr Speaker. Exactly so.

Thank you.

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, as cooperative as the respected Colleague has been, I want to commend him before we proceed.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Do not invite trouble.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He should lay his Papers and leave me in peace.
[Laughter]

PAPERS

By the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs —

- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Births and Deaths Registry for the year 2024.
- (ii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Krachi East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (iii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Jaman North District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (iv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Krachi West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (v) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Krachi Nchumuru District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (vi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Atiwa West

District Assembly for the year 2024.

(vii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tema West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(viii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Mampong Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(ix) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Jasikan Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

2.43 pm

(x) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Juaboso District Assembly for the year 2024.

(xi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the La Nkwantanang-Madina Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(xii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Berekum Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(xiii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga Central Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(xiv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tano North

Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, can we then go back now to look at the item numbered 8(b)? We went past item number 8(b). So, with your permission, if we can take the item numbered 8 (b)(i) and (ii) together. I seek your leave to allow me to do it on behalf of the Majority Leader who is not here at the moment.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minority Leadership, an application has been made.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we have no objection to that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That is wonderful.

Deputy Majority Leader?

PAPERS

By the Deputy Majority Leader on behalf of the Majority Leader —

(xv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Office of the Head of Civil Service for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Public Administration and State Interests.

- (xvi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Commission for Civic Education for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies.

By the Deputy Majority Leader on behalf of the Majority Leader —

- (xvii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the National Commission for Civic Education for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes?
[Pause]

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I want us to go back to the item numbered 7, Statements, if there are any Statements available.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We have so many Statements, but as I sit here, I do not have any Statement with me. I know we have a lot of Statements.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, before we proceed to take the item numbered 7, we just laid a number of items advertised under the name of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs and I want to commend him.

Mr Speaker, we have often bemoaned the delay in the presentation of annual reports to this House. Agencies and a

number of Ministries have defaulted in this regard. To that extent, I want to commend the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. Clearly, he has shown some distinction in this regard. Last week, he did same; we laid a number of annual reports that were advertised in his name and, today, we can see clearly a tall list again.

I think the other Minister should also take a cue. When the reports come to this House late, it undermines the work of the Committees. So, the Deputy Majority Leader should take this in good stride. He should reach out to the Ministers that the reports must come here on time. If we look at all the reports laid, all of them with no exception, are for 2024, which is last year. I know there are a number of reports that are still outstanding in a number of Ministries, so he should, please, reach out to them and let them do the needful. That is when the Committees can have a locus to work.

Mr Speaker, the item numbered 8(e) on page 3 of the Order Paper for today is “Report of the Finance Committee on the Ghana Cocoa Board (Amendment) Bill, 2025”. I brought this to the attention of the Majority Leader and the Deputy Majority Whip was defending it that they had withdrawn it to incorporate an amendment and they were not ready. Let us get a bit clinical; we put out Businesses and we are not ready to prosecute them. This particular item has been there for more than one month. If they are not ready, why do they advertise it?

The Government's Side should listen to me; if they are not ready, they should not advertise these items. For more than a month, the Business has been on the Order Paper—[*Interruption*]—No, you have been bringing *Addendum* Order Paper for urgent Businesses to be prosecuted and we have been cooperating with you.

I am saying that if they are not ready, they should not advertise it. It has been on the Order Paper for more than one month. When this one goes out, what will the public be saying about us? Is that part of their reset agenda? Leadership on the Government Side should be a bit clinical and liaise with the Table Office. If they are not ready, they should not advertise it. We will take strong exception to this. They say they are resetting Ghana; is that how to reset Ghana?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, the very item that the Hon Minority Chief Whip is referring to has been brought to the attention of the Minister for Finance who was actually out of jurisdiction. I think it was explained here that the intention is for the Ministry to withdraw and put another one in place. The Minister is aware of it and he will be coming to do that in the next day or so. That is the issue with that.

I agree, again, with the Minority Whip about the timely presentation of this report to the House. It does not stop there.

2.54 p.m.

We have also been talking about referrals, which are not coming. Once the Reports are presented and referred, we also expect the referrals to come on time because these are compliance issues, and I do agree with you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. So, we will go back to item number 7 — Statements.

I can now see Hon Michael Aidoo here, so Aidoo your students are here, and as lawyers will say, take your victims as you find them. They are here; you have to take care of them.

Mr Aidoo: Yes, Mr Speaker, and I wish to welcome them. The students are the *crème de la crème* of student leaders in Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST), that is the Student Representative Council (SRC) and student Parliament. I want to welcome them to this august House.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. As you have been given the opportunity to welcome them, you have to do the needful.

[Student Leaders of KNUST SRC were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we would start Statement time with Hon Member for Salaga South, Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah. This is a Statement to celebrate the life of Professor Felix Israel Konotey-Ahulu, a

Ghanaian distinguished intellectual with global footprint.

Hon Member, let us hear you. You have the floor now.

STATEMENT

A Personal Tribute to Prof Felix Israel Konotey-Ahulu

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to read this Statement in this august House to celebrate the life of a Ghanaian who left footprints across the globe.

Mr Speaker, on 27th May, 2025, the world woke up to the distressing news of the passing of one of the world's greatest scientists, Prof Felix Israel Konotey-Ahulu, a trailblazer by every measure. A lot could be said about the 94-year lifespan of Professor Konotey-Ahulu. A Ghanaian physician, a Dr Kwegyir Aggrey Distinguished Professor of Human Genetics at the University of Cape Coast (UCC), a consultant physician and genetic counsellor, and haemoglobinopathy/sickle cell states in London. Prof Konotey-Ahulu was one of the world's foremost experts on sickle cell disease.

Mr Speaker, that is the sheer breadth of the man who was born to a Presbyterian minister in Odumase-Krobo in 1930 and died as a towering scientist who taught in, at least, 21 universities around the world, including Turkey, Brazil, Greece, Singapore, Australia, India, Hungary, Canada,

Denmark, Switzerland, Sweden, Ghana, Nigeria, Cameroon, Ivory Coast, Sierra Leone, Liberia, Senegal, Kenya, Tanzania, Zambia, South Africa and Egypt.

Mr Speaker, Professor Konotey-Ahulu was not just an accomplished research scientist, physician and scholar, but he played the piano and even once composed a hymn of seven verses with melody entitled, "Time was created". Mr Speaker, the repertoire of Prof Konotey-Ahulu is too expansive and diverse to register in such a short tribute. In spite of this, I intend in this short tribute to raise my voice as a celebratory dirge to an African intellectual giant whose footprints in both science and community echoed around the world.

Mr Speaker, when I first met Prof Konotey-Ahulu in London, he was already in his autumn years. It was at an event to which he had been invited to at the Ghana High Commission in London where I was stationed as a Minister-Counsellor and Head of Information. In spite of his remarkable achievements, he struck me as an affable, gracious and easily approachable person, deep discerning, gentle in his manners and willing to engage in whatever subject one threw at him. Those who knew him looked at him in awe and treated him with what I later came to learn was well-deserved respect.

Mr Speaker, when I met him later in his professional setting as a physician at his Harley Street practice, I expected to see an impenetrable cold scientist who went about his duties matter-of-factly,

but, again, I found something different. Of course, his knowledge and warmth were impossible to miss. He was quintessentially a medical professional who strived to bring healing and relief to his suffering patients. This is not an easy feat to achieve, especially for a scientist.

For many, being professional is to be stone cold and sometimes, to the point of being unchallenged. It is more so with a scientist whose default training and practice orients him or her to stick doggedly to the facts and nothing more. It is, therefore, to the credit of Prof Konotey-Ahulu that he was not just knowledgeable and warm, but profoundly touched his patients through his humaneness, assuring and fatherly nature.

Mr Speaker, I had battled chronic anaemia and had been to several consulting rooms without a permanent treatment to my condition. In 2010, when I met Prof Konotey-Ahulu in his consulting room, I left with a permanent cure. He diagnosed me of a rare blood condition that inhibited my iron absorption. After this diagnosis, he placed me on an iron supplement called “Fero-Grad C” and he said to me, and I quote, “Zuwera, you can get this drug off the counter with a repeat prescription”. He added that, and I quote again, “Do not worry about the cost because it is cheap, but it will treat your condition”. Till date, I take my Fero Grad C religiously, every day, and it has kept me alive. Cheap, indeed, it was, and it remains cheap.

Mr Speaker, the passion of Prof Konotey-Ahulu straddled medicine; he had a deep-seated affection for his country. As many times as I visited his practice, he found time during consultations to talk about Ghana, a subject he spoke about with great fondness and deep insight. With him, I gained the abiding insight not to lose hope in our country, no matter how dire the situation becomes. This is because while many people I encountered saw the problems of Ghana, Prof Konotey-Ahulu sought and proffered solutions.

He spoke with fondness about the Ghana he conceived where sickle cell and HIV/AIDS will be wiped out. He spoke passionately about the health delivery of the country and suggested practical ways in which funding would not just boost research, but also prop up our health system in ways where infrastructure aligned with scientific research and ultimately, render universal healthcare accessible and efficient.

Mr Speaker, today I raise my voice not only to sing a dirge, but to also invoke the legacy of a departed ancestor whose footprints defied time. A man whose service to humanity defied both borders and disciplines, a man whose conception of his motherland was matched by his willingness to put his shoulder to the wheel and contribute to its development in practical and enduring ways.

Mr Speaker, foremost among the lessons I take out of my encounters with Prof Konotey-Ahulu is the absolute necessity to never give up on our

country. Equally important is the compulsion to do whatever we do in our professions in the public interest. As politicians, this clarion call could not be more resonant and timelier.

3.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, on behalf of the entire Parliament of Ghana, the ordinary people of Ghana who we represent, permit me, Mr Speaker, to extend my deepest condolences to Rosemary, his wife of 63 years; his children: David, Carys, and Lydia; his 11 grandchildren, six great-grandchildren, and his sisters: Edna, Gritty, Ruby, Catherine, and Ann. Our prayers are with the entire extended family of Professor Konotey-Ahulu of Odumase Krobo.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I recognise that, in spite of his humble beginnings, Prof Felix Israel Konotey-Ahulu bestrides the narrow world like a colossus, both in his personal achievements and his impact on the global stage.

Like Mark Antony in Shakespeare's *Julius Caesar*, I keep asking myself, and I quote: "Here was a man, when comes such another"? Rest with the Lord, Prof Felix Israel Konotey-Ahulu, FGA, FRCPSG, FRCP, FWACP.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, yes?

Prof Ayensu-Danquah, are you contributing? Is it that nobody knows him? Very well.

Yes, Prof Ayensu-Danquah, you are a medical doctor so let us hear you say something.

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu-Ketan): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for allowing me to make a comment on this Statement. I would like to thank my Sister for bringing up this topic and also talking about this very important person in the field of medicine, Prof Konotey-Ahulu.

I actually met him in the United Kingdom (UK) sometime in the 2000s when I was doing an externship with the Royal College of Surgeons. That was the first time I met him and he taught me a lot. He told me about medicine in Ghana. He even asked me to come to Ghana to do another externship and I did a lot of research with him on Haematology and specifically with sickle cell.

So, this individual, Mr Speaker, is really a colossus in the medical field. He has contributed a lot to medicine. He has also contributed to Ghana and the image of Ghana medicine outside the country. His diagnosis and some of his research have been really groundbreaking and have also contributed to the treatment of sickle cell.

Mr Speaker, back in the day, we did not know how to treat sickle cell and sickle cell patients had very short mortality rates so they were really dying off quickly. But it took research from

people like Professor Konotey-Ahulu to really come up with proper treatment for sickle cell and especially also for anaemia. So, his work in the field of Haematology is unprecedented. His work as a Ghanaian physician outside the country is unprecedented and for some of us, he was actually our role model. We looked at him, saw the work he was doing outside the country in the name of Ghana and we actually followed him throughout his entire career.

As my Sister said, he is not only a great physician, but he is also a humanitarian. He also composes music and that was one of the reasons when I actually met him, we became friends because my father was also a composer and the choir director for the Methodist church. So those were some of the topics we used to talk about. He is truly a great humanitarian, a great Ghanaian, and a great physician and I thank my Sister for bringing this topic up in this august House.

Once again, I would like to send my heartfelt condolences to his family and his wife. It is very sad when a country loses such important people.

Thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me now come to Leadership.

Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam/Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, this is out of the ordinary and in this

House, we have often witnessed such Statements that are delivered in commemorating politicians. And more often than not, the focus has been personalities who have held notable or politically exposed offices.

We have often not had such Statements and I want to commend my good Friend, Hon Zuwera, who has decided to blaze a different trail in speaking to a scientist, and for that matter, a public servant, not necessarily a politician.

Mr Speaker, I think we need to take a cue and going forward, this is the people's representatives. We must not only be celebrating politicians; we must also find time and space to celebrate such characters. Mr Speaker, in other dispensation, funds are established and foundations are developed in honour of such personalities. I think going forward, we may have to shy away from what we are used to, where the focus, more often than not, has been on politically exposed persons.

One, it gets the youth to be carried along and then when we speak to their legacies, the youth can imbibe into the goodness and the good things they left behind. I think that the science community needs to take a good look at this. Such public-spirited will is something we must make a definite effort to recognise. For me, it is something we have to do. We have a number of research institutions in our country like Noguchi and a number of them—

The state must be seen to be leading the way to be celebrating such personalities who have distinguished themselves, devoid of political colouration and devoid of partisanship. That is how we can build a nation. So that irrespective of one's political persuasion, if indeed the person is out there contributing to the good of our country, they be recognised at the right time and posthumously, they could be given all the recognition that they deserve.

So, I commend my Colleague, and my heart goes out there to the family and the bereaved family entirely.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Majority Leadership?

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan (NDC — Cape Coast South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. First of all, I want to thank my Hon Sister Zuwera, Member of Parliament for Salaga South, for eulogising the Professor who passed on 27th May, 2025.

Mr Speaker, as we have heard, he was a trailblazer. He was a specialist in human genetics and a haemoglobinopathy surgeon. I think it is important that we celebrate, inasmuch as we console the family and express our condolences to the family, we should also celebrate such important people who have obviously contributed to society, contributed to his country, Ghana. Most of the time, these people do these things quietly. They are not politicians; they are not public people

who speak, but they do an important job behind the scenes, which basically keeps us healthy as a country.

3.13 p.m.

I also have to commend my Sister, our own Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah, who herself is a surgeon, for the contribution and what she had said about the professor. I think that it is important that at least in the field of medicine, we get the books written and published by such people so that we can be able to get inheritance in terms of inheriting from such people who have been basically very pioneer in the field of medicine as the Professor had been. My condolences to the family and may his soul rest in peace. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We shall take the second Statement. Hon Members, we have always been advising that if you want to read a Statement, you should try to share copies with your Colleagues; especially, at the other Side so that they will also be able to contribute.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, and the intendment is not to take anything away from his Statement.

Mr Speaker, you have cautioned that we should aspire to ensure that all provisions in the new Standing Order are enforced. Order 93(8) puts the burden on the Clerk. With your permission, I read:

“The Clerk shall make shall available to Members, copies of admitted Statements”

Mr Speaker, the burden is on the Clerk to Parliament and not on Members. So, the Table Office should take note. It is not enough if they put copies here. I see you giving a signal. They should make copies for Members.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, let me defend the Table. Most of the time, the Statements are here, and there are so many of them, and at times, it becomes difficult as to which one we are going to take. I have said this over and over again, but under the circumstances, we cannot blame the Clerks-at-the-Table so much. As far as I know, so many Statements are begging to be read in the House. But we do not know when we would take them. I made that statement—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I like them; they work hard. But I am only reminding them that it is their responsibility. So, they should revert their mind and be guided accordingly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, can we hear you?

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, just to add my voice to what is being said. The making of Statements on the floor of the House is not just a ceremonial thing. The academia uses our *Hansard* and Statements for research. It is in that regard that copies of Statements must not just be given to Hon Colleagues, but they must be asked to also go and make research in that area to support the Statement. So, if you make a

Statement and Members are not able to comment, one may think that Hon Members do not like him or her, and that is why when you made the Statement, they did not talk. But it is because what was supposed to be done, had not been done.

If we listened to the contribution from my Hon Colleague sitting on my left-hand side, the Hon Professor, she personally knows the Professor we are talking about, and they did research together. I was touched by the kind of comment that she made. When I asked, she said, the Member who made the Statement came to tell her this morning that he wants to make a Statement. Maybe, if I was also consulted or given a copy, I would have spoken in the same direction.

So, Mr Speaker, your call is in the right direction, but Members must endeavour to give copies. Apart from the Clerks-at-the-Table doing that job, they should give copies to Hon Colleagues to support them. We do it across the Divide. That is what we used to do, and I think that culture must continue.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well—

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, beyond that, I remember in the Fifth Parliament, a Colleague, Hon Dr Isaac Asiamah showed his Statement to his Chairman of a Committee. We came to the floor, and the Chairman started presenting the Statement. Then, the Ranking Member stood on the other Side and shouted “Mr Speaker, that is my

Statement!”. These are some of the reasons Members after writing their Statement, put it under their armpits.

[Laughter]

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I agree to what the Hon Minority Chief Whip and the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs has just shared but it is not only just giving copies to Colleagues but modern technology actually allows us to be able to place Statements on the console. So, Reports should be put here so that when Members come, they would have adequate time to read and be able to support the Statement if they so wish.

We have other means available to be able to get these Statements to look at. And I am just urging Hon Members to take advantage of this new technology that we have in the Chamber to be fully informed or advised on Statements made and not for copies of the Statement to appear or be shared in the middle of the Statement being delivered. We see Statements on the console being presented at the same time as the Statement is being made, maybe we should be ahead of time in dealing with this issue.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, let us go Subin, Hon Kofi Obiri Yeboah you have the floor now to speak on the embargo placed on the Lands Commission halting the sale, lease and processing of transaction involving state and public lands. I would have wished the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and his Deputy were here.

You will read it but I would have wished they were here to listen to the Statement, but you can take the floor now and read the Statement.

Hold on. Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Mr Speaker you have made a very good intervention, but I would plead that if there is another Statement to be made after this then we could take that one while the Majority Chief Whip—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But the Deputy Minister is here?

[The Hon Deputy Minister for Roads and Highways walks in]

All right, He is the Minister for Roads and Highways. I thought he was the Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources—

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, while the Majority Chief Whip makes a call to the Ministry to see if he can get the Deputy or the Minister himself— Because, when one makes a Statement, and there are consequential orders, the Ministers must assist the Member’s Statement. So that it will not be just a Statement being presented on the Floor. We must walk the talk based on the recommendations that would come from my Colleagues.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, I would hold on with this particular Statement. We are surely going to take it.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I do not have a problem supporting my Colleague. Ideally, that should be it, but Mr Speaker, for the past two weeks, I have been begging the Majority Frontbench to programme the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources on matters on *galamsey*. *Galamseymen* are now digging close to the Accra-Kumasi Road. I have been practically begging—Well, they can say that it is not a subject matter of discussion here, but I am speaking in context. The Minister for Lands and Natural Resources is a Member of Parliament, should we beg him before he comes to the House? —*[Interruption]*— That should not be the case. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Energy and Green Transition and Deputy Minister for Roads and Highways are always here, but I cannot say same for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. He comes and goes. So, I am not objecting—*[Interruption]*—Well, you can speak for him; that is fine. We cannot wait for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources before the Statement is made.

3.23p.m.

No, Parliament cannot wait for them. They should come to the House. This is the representation of the people because it cannot be that we have a Statement to present and then we are lamenting that the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources is not in the House, so we should wait for him to come. Is that what we are turning our Parliament to? I disagree.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon respected Minority Chief Whip, I think it is not the case that we are not going to read a Statement today. The application made by the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is to hold on for the Majority Bench to reach out to them, so that if they can make time to the—I am inclined to do that simply because we have been complaining that we make a lot of referrals and the Ministers and others are not taking action. But if the Minister is here to listen to the Statement, I think the Minister can make—

So, I will hold on and take another Statement before I come back to that.

Yes, Hon Suhuyini?

Alhaji Alhassan: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I think that the Hon Minority Chief Whip is a very good friend of mine, but he has not been charitable at all to the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and I think that is not fair. The Minister of Lands and Natural Resources has sat with me and my Colleague, the Minister for Energy and Green Transition, on this Floor many times. Last week and last two weeks, we have all been in this Chamber and have participated even in the Business. So, to suggest that the two of us are usually here, but he is not here is completely unfair on his part.

I also just want to put on record that the appeal that he is making is not new to this House. I, in the last Parliament, was

on the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources of Parliament. I presented a couple of Statements a number of times and, Mr Speaker, at the time, there were occasions where I was asked to hold on, so that the Minister would be present to, if need be, respond to some of the issues that I sought to raise in the Statements that I made.

Mr Speaker, in fact, there was even one time where the Minister was impressed upon to do something like a counter-Statement to the Statement that I made, so that the two Statements were admitted and read at the same time. So, Mr Speaker, I do not think it is new for this appeal to be made for the Minister to come before a Statement is made.

Thank you very much.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, the intendment was not to cause harm as is being portrayed by my Colleagues—If my statement had created an unfortunate image, unreservedly, I retract the statement regarding the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr Speaker, so, must we wait for him? That is my only concern; must Parliament wait for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources? Maybe, he has spoken to him, so he can speak.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I have reached out to the Deputy Minister who is on his way to the House. So, we can take another Statement, so that, by the end of time for Statements, the Deputy Minister—Even

he is trying to come with the Minister himself, so that they can address this issue. There was a discussion on it yesterday, so he could come and throw more lights on steps taken so far to address the issues.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. I am personally inclined to do that, so if the Deputy Minister is on his way here, I think that is good.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: I read the Business Statement and I give my promise that arrangements would be made to bring the Minister to come and answer any Questions.

But I think, as the Hon Deputy Minister said, it is a bit unfair to single a Minister out. But I am glad that, after eight years, they have finally realised that the *galamsey* issue has actually reached the roadside and it will be addressed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us take it lightly.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: This is a diplomatic jab; the Deputy Majority Leader has attacked me.

Deputy Majority Leader should not do that. He is opening himself up for me to come and jab him; he is my friend. He is allowing some of the Whips to influence him. I have not mentioned the name of anybody. Some of the Whips are actually influencing him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us take some of these things lightly.

Mr Obiri Yeboah — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Obiri Yeboah, we will come to you. Let us take one Statement and then we come back to you. Just hold on.

So, we will take a Statement from Hon Dr Eric Afful.

Hon Obiri, do not go out; we will definitely take your Statement.

Hon Dr Eric Afful would like to talk about the 24-Hour Economy and the accelerated export development programme.

Dr Afful: Mr Speaker, that is not the Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is that not the Statement? That is the one I am holding.

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the Hon Member has two Statements, but what he is about to read is a Statement on the highlights of the positive trend of the economy of Ghana. So, he is not reading the 24-Hour Economy Statement today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He cannot read that one because I do not have it. But why are you running away from this one?

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the communication to him this morning was that he is reading this very Statement.

So, we did not draw his attention to read the 24-Hour Economy today. That one is programmed to be taken either tomorrow or the day after.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, but the point is, is he not the owner of this Statement?

Mr R. Acheampong: He is, but he is not prepared to read it today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You have presented a Statement and the Statement has been admitted and you want to choose when to read the Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I invite you to Order 95. Order 95 – Withdrawal of Statement. It does not lie in his mouth—

Mr Speaker, Order 95 says:

“A Member whose Statement has been admitted may withdraw the Statement by leave of the Speaker.”

It is crystal clear and he is saying that he does not want to read that one. He should seek the leave of the Speaker to do the needful; he should seek the leave of the Speaker and say that he does not want to read this one. He wants to read that one.

Mr Speaker, wonders will never stop happening. They are running away from their own 24-Hour Economy. Jesus Christ! They are running away from the 24-Hour Economy. The President will hear about this; the President must hear about this. They cannot defend their 24-

Hour Economy. I am very sad this afternoon. He has presented two Statements: one which is on their 24-Hour Economy and he is saying he will not do it and that he prefers the other one. But he will also not come under appropriate Orders; what is happening? The President will hear about this. The first reshuffle is going to happen.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Dr Afful: Mr Speaker, I have put in about five Statements to be read. If we can go back to the console, you would realise that this particular Statement I am about to read was captured the whole of last two weeks and last week and I was informed this morning that this Statement will be read, so I brought a copy to read it.

So, if you grant me the leave to go along with the current one I have—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Leave granted; read the one you would want to read. If you want to read—

Dr Afful: Thank you so much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have the floor.

I am not listening to anybody; go ahead and read it.

Highlights on the Positive Trend of the Economy

Dr Afful: Mr Speaker, let me take the opportunity to make this Statement to highlight the positive trend of economy

of Ghana, to educate and encourage ourselves as Ghanaians in decision making as households—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on; do Members have copies?

Some Hon Members: No!

3.33 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Eric Afful, hold on, you will be given the opportunity. Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, once again, the Statement the Hon Member is going to make is on the economy and the progress being made. For such a Statement, Members across the Divide must have copies and rich contributions must be made. It is not just a Statement. Members may give commendation and critique, both constructive and otherwise. So, Mr Speaker, if he wants to make such a Statement, Members must be given copies; it is not just an ordinary Statement.

So, if we are saying that the 24-Hour Economy — whether the Clerks-at-the-Tables have a copy of whatever Statement, he must have copies of his five Statements; Members must be given copies, and whatever Statement he makes, we must be aware of it to make contributions. This is because they are not just ordinary or ceremonial Statements or tributes; these are Statements he is going to make on the progress of the economy, how the cedi is appreciating and how the economy is growing. If he does not give us copies, how would we know?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Have you started contributing?

Mr Ibrahim: No, Mr Speaker. I am telling you that he must make it available in the House and it must be given to Members to go through. Even if the Minister for Finance is not here, Hon John Abdulai Jinapor who has been in opposition for eight years and is now here in Government, must not only be making economic or financial Statements. Energy is even financed and is even part of the economy, so give us copies. If we do not have copies and he is going to make a Statement, how are we going to contribute? Or will he read it and that one will also die?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Yes, Dr Kabiru Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Statement by the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development is an important Statement from the heading, but it is not right that we would want to speak to such a matter and Members do not have copies. I think the Member can come back well by giving Members copies. We still have the day, so the order of Business can be varied for him to come back well.

Mr Speaker, but it is part of the lack of urgency of government institutions and government functionaries taking the Business of this House as a joke. We cannot go on that tangent. My senior and Minister wanted to read the Statement on

behalf of the Member. I know my senior Brother and Minister for Energy and Green Transition was equally nodding to the fact that he was reading his Statement by saying that the cedi is appreciating. Mr Speaker, as we speak now, even Mr Sammy Gyamfi quotes the dollar as GH¢12.50 and he is talking about the appreciation of the cedi.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Dr Kabiru Mahama, you have also started commenting.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am drawing your attention to the issues he raised. While they raise those issues, they should allow the Hon Colleague to read the Statement. I believe in the sincerity, honesty and academic prowess of my Colleague to present a Statement that can stand the test of time in this House. If it is laced with politics, this Side of the House is well-prepared to audit every single sentence; we will cross every “t” and dot every “I” of that Statement. If that Statement is laced with propaganda, we are equally equipped to expose that propaganda. So, this Side is ready for the Statement. Let us upload it and read it. He would present it and we would critique it accordingly.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I hope Members have, at least, been given enough copies.

Dr Eric Afful: Mr Speaker, as at last week, I had brought about 20 copies of this Statement to share to Members, so most Members on my right have copies.

Most of my Members on the left, have copies.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, just go ahead and read the Statement.

Positive Trend of the Economy of Ghana

Dr Eric Afful (NDC — Amenfi West): Mr Speaker, thank you so much and I would like to take the opportunity to make this Statement to highlight the positive trend of the economy of Ghana to educate and encourage ourselves as Ghanaians in decision-making, households, businessmen and even Governments which have signed social contracts with these people.

Mr Speaker, governance is about seeking the welfare of the people, especially about their respective standards of living in a country. This is measured by the amount of goods and services available for consumption as well as its affordability by adopting a mechanism used to allocate or distribute the goods and services among the citizenry in a country.

Mr Speaker, the effectiveness and efficient mechanism designed to allocate the said resources are measured by certain economic and financial indices, data and statistics in a country. Some of these include the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) of a country, the rate of inflation which measures the general price levels of goods and services in a country over a period of time, the gross international reserves of a country, the

Balance of Payment (BoP), the primary fiscal balance of trade, the national debt level of a country and its associated national debt to GDP ratio.

Mr Speaker, the Consumer Price Index (CPI) of a country is also a good measure to this effect. The Central Bank Monetary Policy and interest rates also counts a lot. Above all is the strength of the cedi in relation to the hard currencies in the world such as US dollar, the UK Pound S0terling, the euro in the European countries and other currencies in the world.

Mr Speaker, data and statistics available, according to the 124th Report of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) and figures from the Ghana Statistical Service (GSS) indicated that the economy of Ghana is striving on a growth path which will eventually lead to sustainable growth and development in the country.

Mr Speaker, inflation which was taken in January 2025 at 23.4 per cent, now stands at 18.3 per cent as at May 2025, which has been programmed to hit mid-teens by the middle of the year. According to the report on the domestic front, the banks high frequency indicators point to a sustained pick-up in economic activity. The updated composite index of economic activity increased by 2.3 per cent on year in March 2025 compared to 1.0 per cent over the same period last year, 2024.

In addition, Mr Speaker, the Purchasing Managers Index (PMI) rose above the 50-benchmark as output and

new orders increased, signalling improved growth and prospects. According to the 124th Report of the BoG Monetary Policy Committee, it indicates that based on inflationary pressures and options above the macroeconomic conditions, the latest Confidence Survey showed a significant improvement in business and consumer indices, the highest in the last seven years.

Mr Speaker, the headline inflation has declined consecutively within the year according to BoG by 2.6 percentage points to 2.12 per cent in April 2025 and 18.3 percent in May 2025. This resulted in reduction of price of goods and services in the country. The primary fiscal balance on commitment basis has also improved significantly in the first quarter of 2025.

3.43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, according to the report, at the end of March 2025, the stock of public debt stood at GH¢769.4 billion, representing 55 per cent of GDP compared to GH¢726.7 billion, also representing 61.8 per cent of GDP at the end of December 2024.

Mr Speaker, according to the current Report of the BoG, the external sector has continued to improve. Mr Speaker, the provisional current accounts earned a surplus of US\$2.1 billion at the end of the first quarter of 2025, mainly driven by high prices and production volumes of gold and cocoa and strong remittance inflow. Mr Speaker, the overall balance of payments registered is a surplus of

US\$1.1 billion in the first quarter of 2025, with a significant reserve accumulation.

Mr Speaker, the strong external performance resulted in a significant reserve accumulation. According to the Report, the gross international reserve amounted to US\$10.7 billion in April 2025, equivalent to 4.7 months of import cover of goods and services. Mr Speaker, the gross international reserve has been programmed to hit 4.0 months of import cover at the end of 2025 to the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. This shows that, broadly, the external sector outlook remains favourable, likely anchored on expectations of increased gold and cocoa receipts, as well as inflow from remittances.

Mr Speaker, according to the Report, the cedi has rebounded strongly against the major trading currencies, driven by a combination of factors, including the tight monetary stance, ongoing fiscal consolidation, record reserve accumulation, strict enforcement of foreign exchange rules, and improved market sentiment.

Mr Speaker, on 21st May, 2025, the cedi had appreciated against all currencies. Mr Speaker, the Ghana cedi appreciated by 24.1 per cent against the US dollar, 16.2 per cent against the British Pound Sterling, and 14.1 per cent against the euro. Mr Speaker, the Monetary Policy (MPC) Report by the BoG still holds the monetary policy reach at 28 per cent.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's economy continues to show more strides locally

and internationally. The economy is growing rapidly and has seen an advantage internationally. Mr Speaker, due to the current performance of the economy, the Switzerland government has awarded a grant of US\$77 million to support the development of a resilient and forward-looking economy of Ghana. Switzerland has pledged its support to Ghana through economy, trade, governance, democracy, peace and security, environment and climate change, as well as sustainable development.

Mr Speaker, I would therefore entreat all to simply support the Government in achieving the targeted financial and economic indices stated in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before I invite comments, let me read our Standing Orders 93(5) to you, because I want to remind you, and I hope this comment on the Statement is not going to be a precursor to the Mid-Year Budget Review. Order 93 (5) says:

“A Member may comment on the statement for a period not exceeding five minutes, and the comment shall not provoke debate.”

I am bringing this to your attention, knowing very well how this Statement is pregnant with a lot of debatable issues.

So, before I invite the first person, kindly indulge me five minutes' suspension.

3.49 p.m. — *Sitting suspended*

3.51 p.m. — *Sitting resumed*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me thank you for your indulgence. Let me start with Hon Member for New Juaben North.

Nana Osei-Adjei (NPP — New Juaben North): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. Mr Speaker, I am going to be very mindful of Order 93(5), but since it is a Statement that highlights the positive strengths of an economy, you give me a bit of latitude to do some comparison because one cannot speak on the economy without doing a little bit of comparison.

Mr Speaker, an economy—
[*Interruption*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, should I conclude that—

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, I am being mindful of Order 93(5).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, please, just be mindful that it should not be a debatable discussion. If you want to also make a Statement on the other side, you can also do so with a Statement and say the negative aspect of the economy. Just be mindful, please.

Nana Osei-Adjei: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. This is a good Statement by the respected Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development. He has elaborated on a lot of indicators.

Mr Speaker, an economy that is seeing positive strengths should, as a matter of fact, see price stability in the country. As a matter of fact, there should be full employment in the country. Mr Speaker, if I refer to page 4 of the Statement, the respected Chairman talks about Marginal Propensity to Consume (MPC) rate of 28 per cent. Mr Speaker, MPC rate of 28 per cent is how much the commercial banks are getting from the Central Bank.

Mr Speaker, if you go on to the street, the interest rate in most of the banks is between 33 per cent to 39 per cent. In an economy that is showing positive strengths, we are not experiencing interest rates that are good for the consumers.

Mr Speaker, this economy that is showing positive strengths has a lot of inefficiencies. Mr Speaker, an economy that is showing positive strengths is directly proportional to economic growth. If it is directly proportional to economic growth, then the managers of the economy should be implementing expansionary fiscal policies. Mr Speaker, but what do we see now? We are seeing contractional fiscal policies that is hindering employment.

Mr Speaker, I will end by saying that we spent a lot of time in this Chamber agreeing to the d-Levy. Mr Speaker, what do we see now? Just the throw of stones from Israel to Iran forced this Government, an economy that is showing positive strengths, to stop the implementation of the d-Levy.

Mr Speaker, I say that it is the throw of stones because it is nowhere compared to what was happening in Ukraine and Russia. In Iran and Israel, they are just throwing stones and an economy that is showing positive strengths has not been able to implement the d-Levy.

Mr Speaker, I will say that this Statement is good but I will advise the respected Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development to bring this Statement again in December so that we can actually compare the figures.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Ntoso, do you want to speak? Are you taking the floor to speak?

Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso: No, just point of order.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, point of order is over now. I decided not to call you.

Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso: I want to correct something. He said in Israel they are throwing stones. He should not belittle what is happening there. If he says that they are throwing stones—Iran and Israel are throwing stones. When people are dying, he is talking about stones throwing. It was not the days of David and Goliath where David threw a stone and killed Goliath. This one, they are firing weapons. So, he has to withdraw. He should not belittle this.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, the Reverend has spoken, so it is alright.

Nana Osei-Adjei: Thank you, Mr Speaker but I was in the context as in the case of Russia and Ukraine.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I appreciate the context. Thank you. Yes, let me invite the Hon Minister for Energy and Green Transition.

Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Mr John Abdulai Jinapor) (MP): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, let me commend the maker of the Statement for the research he has conducted. Very in-depth, very accurate, and he gives the timelines, and I find this very educative. Beyond the politics, what we are doing is an academic exercise that helps all of us, and I think that we should encourage such research to anchor what we do here in Parliament.

Facts are facts. Facts are sacrosanct. One may put an interpretation on the facts, but facts can only be one. He has given the facts about inflation, exchange rates, GDP growth, debt to GDP, the primary balance, the current account, the fiscal balance, and all that. Are they accurate or not? They are accurate. If one has a counter-information, the person should put it out here. If one wants to put an interpretation on it, that is their own opinion. Is it true that inflation has improved? It has improved and so if you see prices going up— when they say inflation is low, it does not mean prices are coming down. It simply means that the rate at which prices are going up is slowed down. He did not talk about

disinflation. He did not talk about deflation. He said inflation is lowering and that is a fact. He spoke about the exchange rate. Is it doing well or not? Year on year, it is doing well and to say that it has not translated, no, there is something you call lag. The lag, or the transmission mechanism in economics.

The fact that Mr Speaker looks healthy today, looking handsome, does not mean he ate today. It could be that yesterday's food, the day before yesterday's food, which is "T-1" is what is accounting for today. That is why when one is computing an equation, one accounts for the lag or the previous year of the dependent variable in order to make sure that what you are doing is robust and so please, the fact that one has not seen prices going down immediately does not mean it would not go down. What you want to do is to sustain this positive trend for a period of time because prices are downward sticky. Prices easily go up; they do not easily come down.

So, I think that, Mr Speaker, let us rather find out how we can support Government to anchor these positive developments and make them sustainable. Because the current trajectory is not just about GDP growth. We are talking of inclusive, sustainable growth that translates into job creation and for me, having attained these positive indices, the next thing we should be looking at is how we can translate that to create jobs for the people of Ghana and I think that if we focus on that, it will help us very much.

Mr Speaker, he talks about expansionary fiscal policy. When you reduce taxes, that is an expansionary fiscal policy. It means that you are putting money in the pockets of the people. If Government spends, that is an expansionary fiscal policy. If you lower interest rates, that is an expansionary fiscal policy. So, I do not understand what other expansionary fiscal policy he wants to see. Look, Mr Speaker, when something is good, admit that it is good.

4.03p.m

Mr Speaker, no as for that one, these two Ladies seated here are beautiful by whatever standard. So, you cannot argue with—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You said they are what?

Mr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, these two Ladies, by all standards, by whatever measure, are beautiful. Whether you like them or you hate them, they are beautiful. Even Mr Speaker is nodding his head. The fact that Mr Speaker is nodding his head attests to the statement I am making—*[Laughter]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No comments—*[Laughter]*

Mr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, in conclusion, let me commend the maker of the Statement for that in-depth research but also advise Government and all of us, including our Members on the other Side, to support Government on this positive trajectory. So, that we can continue to strengthen and anchor the

Ghanaian economy and make it the economy that we all aspire to have.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if you have observed, I am not taking all those standing on point of order. I want the comments to flow. Whatever it is, note them down and I would give you the opportunity to address them.

Yes, Hon Member for Manso Nkwanta?

Yes, Second Deputy Minority Whip?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I understand that you respectfully want the comments to flow, but does it mean that people can say whatever they want?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, if—

Mr Shaib: Yes, so, Mr Speaker, respectfully, we cannot say that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if I assess it and see that the Statement needs to be attended to or make the maker withdraw, I will do so.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Very well, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Manso Nkwanta, let us hear you.

Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity and I want to use this opportunity to thank the Hon Member, the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development for the Statement made.

Mr Speaker, indeed, there has been improvement in some macroeconomic parameters this year and that is good for Ghana. However, we need to understand and unpack the basis for these improvements that we have seen. For macroeconomic indicators, what is important is their sustainability. It is not the point-in-time figure that we see. So, we need to understand the basis for their improvement. We need to understand why they are where they are.

If you look at the first indicator that we are all talking about, which is the value of the local currency — Mr Speaker, this has been debated severally and I would be brief. There is no doubt that the trade issues that we have had around the world, starting from actions that were taken by the United States Government, have actually impacted the strength of our local currency. Because based on that trade issues around the globe, we have seen major trading currencies losing value on their own. So, relatively, it is making our cedi look good.

Mr Speaker, some other indicators that have supported the strength of the cedi is the gold reserves and there is no doubt about that. But it is factual that, this year, the amount of gold reserves

that we have added is just about one metric tonnes. So, it is not that much.

Mr Speaker, again, the issue of balance of payment is one of the key economic metrics that actually supports the strength of the local currency. Yes, if we look at the trend, the balance of payment has gone up as indicated by the maker of the Statement. But if we read further to also understand what is behind the balance of payment, we would understand that, yes, two key commodities of the country: cocoa and gold have supported a balance of payment. So, we ask ourselves, cocoa and gold, especially, cocoa, is it that we have done something structurally different to produce more cocoa or what has happened? If one looks at it, they would understand that it is because the world trade price of cocoa has improved. But is it sustainable? We do not control world market price.

So, if balance of payment has gone up because market prices have gone up, we cannot commend ourselves for that. Actually, what is worrying is the light crop season for cocoa this year. We have been told by Ghana Cocoa Board (COCOBOD) that, this year, the volumes would be short by 10,000 metric tonnes. So, we should be worried that the volume of cocoa for this light crop season is rather going down. So, if world market price goes down now, we are done and the balance of payment that we are priding ourselves in would be nothing to talk about.

Mr Speaker, another point is inflation. Now, we have seen inflation

trending down, which is good for the country. It gives value to everything. But let us ask ourselves, with inflation, what have we done to send inflation tumbling? Have we done anything specifically to send inflation tumbling? That is the big question. If we look at inflation, we would understand that the reduction is not coming from the food basket; it is rather coming from the non-food basket and where we are benefiting is also not determined by us.

We had the price of crude oil going down earlier in the year, which led to transport fees also coming down. All these impacted to send inflation down. If we look at the food segment, inflation has not gone down that much. It is really insignificant. So, we ask ourselves that what have we really done to bring inflation down? If it is based on some global trade crisis, like fuel, then we should not pat ourselves on the back.

Mr Speaker, in all, I would say it is rather too early for anyone to be patting himself on the back because all that we are seeing are issues that are happening across the globe and we are benefiting. If we look at trade tariffs by the United States Government, we had a pause of about 90 days. This 90-day period is ending and right away, we would now see the real effects on us. On that basis, we will now really be assessing ourselves if we have done something special to see these metrics improving.

Mr Speaker, in all, I would say it is rather too early for us to start partying that we have made macroeconomic parameters look good. These are based

on international issues of which we have not played much part.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Let me go to Berekum.

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah (NDC — Berekum West): Mr Speaker, I rise to commend the Hon Member, who is also the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development, for elucidating the economic gains that this country has chalked under the governance of H. E. John Dramani Mahama and the prudent economic management of the Minister for Finance and the other Ministers of State.

Mr Speaker, it is my prayer that, from time to time, the leadership of the various Committees will address the House regarding issues within the purviews of their respective Committees.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member talked about the inflation, which stood at over 23 per cent in January and now hovering around 18 per cent. It is refreshing and also to put on record that Fitch Solutions has projected that, in the coming days, inflation is projected to drop further to about 15 per cent.

Mr Speaker, it is also important for us to recognise that, as a result of the prudent management of the economy, all the international rating agencies are now painting positive outlook of the Ghanaian economy.

4.11p.m.

Not long ago, we are where Fitch Ratings upgraded Ghana from restricted default to stable outlook, that is “B-”. I am very confident that in the coming days, Moody’s Rating, S&P, and other agencies will equally be painting a very good picture of the Ghanaian economy.

Mr Speaker, again, we are aware that in the first quarter, the economy saw a 5.3 per cent growth year on of the GDP and this, once again, is an indication of how well this economy is being managed.

Again, without belabouring the point already made by Colleague Members, we are aware the performance of the cedi against all the major currencies in the last six months has been very sterling. It is, therefore, important for this House to recognise that these gains were not achieved just on their own, but were achieved as a result of the deliberate, prudent, and fiscal discipline that this Government has undertaken.

On that note, once again, Mr Speaker, I would like to conclude by thanking the maker of the Statement and pray that the leadership of other Committees will emulate same and from time to time, address this House on issues within their areas.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Kabiru? I will take your comments, take another from this Side, then I will come to Leadership.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, Hon Eric Afful, the Chairman of the Committee on Development and Economy of Parliament, presented a Statement. I am quite happy that in his position now, in power and in Government, he now understands the real economics as opposed to the propaganda economy.

I am happy and very much so because my respected senior, Hon Jinapor, who was very articulate on the other Side on the economy and energy has, today, found the real understanding of economics as opposed to the propaganda economy, and I will start from there. He now understands the real meaning of inflation.

When he was on the other Side, he told us that inflation is this and why is the price of goods increasing? Today, he has made us understand that inflation is not the same as disinflation; that when they say inflation is reducing, it does not necessarily mean prices of goods and services are coming down.

Mr Speaker, since time immemorial, prices of goods and services have never come down because as he rightly mentioned, prices are not sticking downwards, and that is common case law in economics, that prices of goods and services are not expected to be on a downward trend. They are supposed to adjust. This is because when prices of

goods and services are decreasing, it means that there is going to be a disincentive for production. No rational producer will want to produce when prices of goods and services are decreasing and that is one thing I am happy that they have understood.

Mr Speaker, I am equally happy that this House has been informed of the transmission mechanism. He talked about time lag, T-1, very elucidate and very good point, but he failed to remind him of the implication of the time lag on the positive figures he mentioned. That is one thing he failed to tell him, that time lag has effect on the positive figures he mentioned. I expected him to have told him that.

Mr Chairman, when I talk of time lag, it means that the policy put in place at a particular time may have effect in one year's time. Some of them will have effect in six months and others in two years. That was the point he mentioned. Today, he understands time lag, but he has failed to remind him that time lag has an effect on the inflation figure he mentioned, the debt-to-GDP, the gross reserve ratio, the balance of payment, and the current accounts. He failed to tell him, but I will help him.

Mr Speaker, there is one thing we fail to do in this country and in this Chamber, that is when a government puts in policies and those policies are working, we need to commend them. I am one person that would be willing to commend the Government.

One of the reasons we are experiencing the appreciation of the cedi is fiscal policy. We admit that it contributes, but we have been reminding this Government that much of the impact is due to the direct intervention of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) in the market, which is antithetical to the free and liberal market we are operating. The direct, unmitigated intervention by the pushing and injection of hard currency into the Ghanaian economy is not economy. Any Minister for Finance or Governor of the Bank of Ghana can do that.

We will allow prices of goods and services in the market and we will allow demand and supply of the currency to determine the price of the Ghanaian cedi, but I have a problem with that intervention, Mr Speaker. The problem with that intervention is that it creates a false sense of the strength of the Ghanaian cedi. When we inject dollars into the Ghanaian economy, it creates a false sense that that will make investors think that the cedi is doing well, but in actual sense, it is not doing well. The IMF has actually come to the country and have mentioned that the Bank of Ghana must stop. This House must encourage the Bank of Ghana to stop the measures of intervening and injecting hard currency into the economy.

Mr Speaker, he mentioned debt-to-GDP. What has the Government done? The Government has not paid any loan, except those we have so agreed to pay. Government has actually contracted more loans, but the debt-to-GDP is declining. Why? Because of the painful

decision of the Government of Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo to go for the Debt Restructuring and the IMF Support Programme. Now, they are taking the credit.

Today, they are taking the credit and they are telling us that the debt-to-GDP is 54 per cent, but they forgot to tell the House what has accounted for the reduction in the debt-to-GDP. The Government has not done anything about the debt situation; absolutely nothing. Yet, the debt-to-GDP has moved to 54 per cent. He needed to tell this House that it is decreasing because the Government painfully took the Debt Restructuring Programme, painfully went to the IMF for a Fund Programme and they are gaining this momentum because of the intervention of Nana Addo Dankwa.

We need to mention one thing, the IMF Programme. The IMF Programme has been highlighted as one of the saviours, but come to think of it, inflation has been declining. IMF told us in 2024 that we should end 2025 with inflation at 17 per cent. Even before they came into Government, that was the projection. So, if we find inflation at 18 per cent or 17 per cent, it should tell them that that is what we had already programmed.

They are now telling us that when we got the positive gains in 2017/2018, it was because we were under the IMF Support Programme. Today, are we not under the IMF Support Programme and they are talking about their successes? Mr Speaker, these successes we are having are also supported by the same

IMF Programme that they criticised, so until we are out of the Fund Programme—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Kabiru, can you wind up for me?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the proximity to the Leadership—

Mr Worlanyo —*rose*—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Worlanyo, allow me to handle the House, please.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am guided; I will try to wind up.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please, wind up for me.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, in winding up, it must be put on record that the foundation upon which most of the macroeconomic indicators are now going to the north, instead of going to the south is because of a certain difficult austerity measure taken and that the Government that took those decisions should be commended.

4.21 p.m.

It must also be placed on record that when the Government does certain good, it must also be supported to continue.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, we cannot say that we are doing well when statutory payments are not being released. How do we say we are doing well? Contractors are not paid. We are in arrears. Even his Ministry has not even

received their funds; he complains in private. The Ministry of Finance is not giving financial clearance to give to people. So, Mr Speaker, I want to thank the maker of the Statement for this Statement, but to tell them that let us put the records straight and when we are giving such Statements, it should be 360 and not one-sided.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Thomas Worlanyo Tsekpo?

Mr Thomas Worlanyo Tsekpo (NDC — Hohoe): Mr Speaker, I will just do three minutes. Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity and let me commend the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development for educating all of us, especially the Minority—*[Interruption]*—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this House has been decorous for some time. Please, just allow him to speak. So, Hon Worlanyo Tsekpo, let us hear you.

Mr Tsekpo: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Today, I have seen one honest Minority Member, that is the MP for Manso Nkwanta commending Government for doing well—*[Interruption]*—That is what I have seen. One honest—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please, you were called to comment on the Statement.

Yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, at the beginning of the Statement, you referred us to Order 93 (5), where it says:

“A Member may comment on the statement for a period not exceeding five minutes, and the comment shall not provoke debate”.

So far, Mr Speaker, we have got some Members speaking for more than five minutes, which is a violation, and we have some Members provoking debate; that is also a violation.

Mr Speaker, you directed that it should flow and that you are not going to allow any intervention, but I think we are going contrary to what we had agreed on. So, I will urge Members on both Sides to respect the Speaker and let the Statement flow the way it should, without any comments that are going to provoke debate.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members—

Hon Member, you have spoken, is that not it? I have not called you.

Hon Leader, I will come to you.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I think the available Leader, the respected Deputy Majority Leader, who is sitting in for his boss, has made a good point to the House. Mr Speaker, I enjoyed the submission on this very

important subject matter of our Hon Colleague who caught your eye, right from my office. In fact, that is what brought me in here.

Mr Speaker, one of the things we must always do is to complement one another and to be measured in language use. We all make mistakes sometimes, we do not always command Grammar and control it. But, Mr Speaker, I would want to encourage my respected Colleague, who is also a first-timer that we are all learning. We do not say we have observed somebody out of the lot making an honest - there is a way—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, if some of the Hon Young Ladies do not have the resilience, they must be quiet. If they start to talk when their Leader is on his feet, then when the people come after them, they will be crying.

Mr Speaker, I would want to encourage my Colleague; her name is not even here. We have heard it in the rumour mill that she is going to be facing the Appointments Committee and this is what she wants to be doing? She came to meet Hon Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings here, the daughter of the founder, the owner of the party— but for some strange reason, it appears her name is coming here and she will not – they have even delayed in the names. She came to meet Hon Helen Ntoso—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader?

Prof Ayensu-Danquah — *rose* —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Then she wants to be rising on the point of order when her Leader is on his feet.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let her sit down.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The angle you are going towards —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, she has to sit down. Mr Speaker, the Rules of this House, in particular, Order 123 – Mr Speaker, I want the Hon Member to pay due regard to this. It is titled “Content of speech”. I will not belabour it but it admonishes all of us to avoid the “use of offensive, abusive, insulting, blasphemous, or unbecoming words”. So, the Hon Colleague should please make her comments. She should avoid certain expressions that may be offensive to her Colleagues. I am sure, Mr Speaker, that is the very call of Hon Ricketts-Hagan, and I am adding my voice to that call.

Mr Speaker, that said, I would want to resume my seat for the Member to proceed with his own comment. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Worlanyo? Prof Ayensu-Danquah, I have not given you the floor. Hon Worlanyo?

Mr Tsekpo: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: As to whether somebody spoke beyond five minutes, I am using my time to assess it. So, please, start speaking, I will know when the five minutes is up. I am going

to be fair to everybody. So, just make your comment.

Mr Tsekpo: Let me again thank the maker of this very important Statement for educating us and allaying the fears of Ghanaians about what some of our Colleagues say and the sand they have been throwing in the eyes of the public.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement made it clear that through the better management of the economy as compared to the previous government, inflation has come down, which is true. It is a fact that we cannot take away from the Minister for Finance, the Governor of the Bank of Ghana, and all the managers of this very economy.

4.31 p.m.

Interest rates have come down and it is a fact that the dollar, which was GH¢17.00 is now GH¢10.00 on the market. It is a fact that one cannot take away from this Government. Mr Speaker, all this was not out of the blue moon because some people had the opportunity six months ago, and they could not do what we are doing today.

Mr Speaker, six months —
[*Interruption*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, like I said, you can go about your contribution without necessarily invoking debate because the way you are going and the way you are speaking, it is like you are actually asking your Colleagues to also come in.

Hon Member, please.

Mr Tsekpo: Mr Speaker, it is a personal observation I have made and it is the same thing my Colleagues also did, comparing the previous Government and this particular Government. It is not different — [*Interruption*]— What I am saying is not different from what they did. It is not—

Mr John Darko: How can you say that the dollar is GH¢10.00 and that is a fact. That is not a matter of fact. [*Uproar*]

Mr Tsekpo: It is a fact. Mr Speaker, it is a fact that six months ago— [*Uproar*]—What we have done in six months, they could not do it in eight years. It is a fact.

Mr Speaker, all this was not out of the blue. It is because of the fiscal discipline. Mr Speaker, now, today, we have 56 Ministers. They had about 120 Ministers. Mr Speaker, that alone—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on. Leader, we have done this without allowing any interjections and I want us to go that way.

You are a Leader, that is why—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, many a time, when Members of Parliament make Statements, it gets into the records of the House. It is captured by *Hansard*. Mr Speaker, to the effect that our Colleague said the dollar was trading at GH¢17.00, is factually incorrect. And even today, the Bank of

Ghana rate is not even GH¢10.00. So, he cannot even say that a dollar to cedi is GH¢10.00. That is not correct. Mr Speaker, you must direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to or direct that this should be expunged from the records. Because the dollar before the — Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance has appeared before the House. He presented a Budget; he appeared here twice, and he said what he inherited in terms of the cedi to dollar, was GH¢14.00 as at then — *[Uproar]*.

Mr Speaker, it was GH¢14.00; it is on our record. Mr Speaker, and today — *[Uproar]*

Mr Speaker, today, when one picks up his or her phone, those who are using iPhone, it is as easy as that. Just click on your calculator, click on convert, and then you press US\$1; it is not 10. So, that cannot be accurate.

Mr Speaker, it must be expunged from the records.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that is why I said we do not have to degenerate into this angle.

Hon Members, are you listening to me? He mentioned GH¢17.00. You are challenging it. You also mentioned GH¢14.00, they are also challenging it. So, that is why I said that when he finishes, you can then state your position. Other than that, we will go the way we are going, and it will be an endless debate. So, please let—

At the preamble of this comment, we said nobody should interject. Let us allow Members to flow.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I am not interjecting. As I said earlier, the things we are talking about in terms of the Statement must flow. If a Member says a dollar is at a certain amount, the right question should be, at what date is the person referring to? So, you cannot assume that if somebody says something is GH¢17.00, it means last year, the year before, or today. So, I think the right question is, if we want the House to have facts, then that is what we should do.

So, just wait for him to finish.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Worlanyo Tsekpo?

Mr Tsekpo: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The fact remains the fact that dollar in this country ever went up to the ceiling of GH¢17.00. It is a fact they cannot take away.

Mr Speaker, and all these economic successes that we have chalked did not come out of the blue but it is the fiscal discipline — that is why I mentioned, the reduction of the number of Ministers, 120 plus, to 56. Even the four has not been added. All this amounted to the discipline that we have in our economy today.

Mr Speaker, it is surprising, that our Colleagues are saying that all this discipline, all these successes are not reflecting. Mr Speaker, just last week, I was in my Constituency, weedicides that we were buying at a cost of GH¢90.00 six months ago, I bought it for GH¢45.00. This is a reflection — a true reflection of the economy.

Mr Speaker, today they are buying petrol and diesel cheaper than they left it. Those who are complaining today, criticising the very economy that we are all enjoying today, are buying diesel, petrol at GH¢11.00, which they cannot deny. Mr Speaker, this same economy is paying back school fees that our students have paid, that is the first year of tertiary education.

Mr Speaker, this same economy that they are criticising, is providing fertilisers to our farmers, — the Feed Ghana Programme, something that they could not do in eight years. Mr Speaker, this same economy is paying allowances that they could not pay to tertiary students — the Economy they handled eight years ago.

Mr Speaker, all what we are trying to say is that Hon Ato Forson, the Governor and the managers of the economy have managed this particular economy in six months more than they have done in eight years. They are enjoying; they are benefiting from it. It is something they cannot take away—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, I think I was going to bring it to a close, but now that I have seen Hon Oppong Nkrumah, I do not know whether he would want to speak. Hon Member, will you speak? No, I want to know whether you will speak.

Hon Members, I want, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, who is the Ranking Member for the Committee on Economy and Development — that is why I am insisting.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we had agreed that when the last speaker over there speaks, it will come to Leadership, and then we will draw the curtain. I am yielding my place—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But I saw Hon Oppong Nkrumah, that is why I want to go one-one again.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Well, Mr Speaker, it is your prerogative.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, I will call Hon Oppong Nkrumah, then I will come to you, then I will come to Leadership. If he does not want to speak, he can yield it to somebody. So that is why I wanted to know whether he wants to speak.

Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, before you speak, please let me acknowledge our children at the Public Gallery. They came in very late. They are from Horizon Peaceland Academy. They are being led by Mr Emmanuel Tetteh, who is the director of the school.

4.41 p.m.

And the school is located at Ledzokuku Constituency. Hon Ayiku, those are your children. I hope you are going to take good care of them. I believe so; go and do that.

So, our children, you are welcome. I hope you are going to study hard, so that, tomorrow, you will also come and take over from us. We wish you a fruitful stay in Parliament. You may sit down.

[Pupils from Horizon Peaceland Academy were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, may we hear you?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity and I want to commend the Chairman of the Committee on the Economy and Development for the Statement he has made, which has introduced, back onto the floor of this House, a number of subjects for us to consider. In the commentary that has come, Mr Speaker, unfortunately, there has been some distortion that I think that, even as we all elucidate, we should try to correct.

First is the subject of the exchange rate. Yes, there has been an appreciation of the Ghana cedi and nobody can say he is unhappy about that, but what is the cause? Among other things, quite recently, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) has quite clearly explained part of what is happening that the

Government has dumped about US\$1.4 billion from our dollar reserves onto the market. If a country has US\$1.4 billion of dollar reserves to dump onto the market to help its currency appreciate, two questions must be asked: the first, where did those reserves come from? And the second, how sustainable is it?

Mr Speaker, it is a matter of fact that, in the six months of this Administration, it has not generated US\$1.4 billion in terms of new additions to our gross international reserves. The truth is that, at the point of inheriting power, the previous Administration had left over US\$8 billion of international reserves, part of which the new administration has drawn and dumped onto the market. So, as we discuss the performance of the economy, credit should be given where credit is due.

The second part of that argument, Mr Speaker, is how sustainable it is. How sustainable is it to continuously be dumping US\$1.4 billion onto the Ghanaian market in a six-month period? Do we have that kind of reserves? it, therefore, calls for some more honest and prudent economic planning beyond an attempt to take fiscal plaudits.

Mr Speaker, the next matter I want to speak to is the subject of fiscal discipline. Sometimes, you hear fiscal discipline being bandied about. Fiscal discipline does not mean a failure to meet your fiscal targets. If you programme to raise, for example, a billion and spend US\$800 million and leave a balance of US\$200 million, you do not fail to raise your billion and just, maybe, raise about

US\$300 million, spend US\$100 million, and say that is fiscal discipline because you have still achieved \$US200 million. No, that is not it because there are a lot of public goods and services you have programmed to do with that US\$800 million.

Today, Mr Speaker, we were here in this Chamber when the Minister for Finance represented to us that so much money had been sent to the district assemblies and that under the District Assemblies Common Fund, about 80 per cent allocation is going to the assemblies. All of us here in the Chamber know that none of the districts has received that money. So, if the Government has not mobilised and spent that money and it keeps touting fiscal discipline, it will come back to haunt them.

Mr Speaker, currently, the Government has launched the US\$1 million Coders programme, agriculture for economic transformation known as Feed Ghana, National Apprenticeship Programme, and a number of other programmes. They even announced recently that they have signed a contract to send over 2,000 Ghanaians to work abroad. We all know that no money has been released for these programmes, so there are no real beneficiaries on the ground.

So, this argument of fiscal discipline that you want to tout as rhetoric, Mr Speaker, we encourage our Colleagues, is not backed by the numbers. Their numbers have not exactly performed, so you have not spent. It is now that moneys are being mobilised to be released to the

Ministries, Departments, and Agencies (MDAs), so that cannot be defined as fiscal discipline. The failure to perform on the fiscal programme is not fiscal discipline.

Mr Speaker, finally, conversations border around relief in the economy. Yes, it is true that, as the cedi has appreciated, it has translated into a lower cost of various items that are imported, but we have already discussed the sustainability and the why. But even at the same time, the Government has increased electricity tariffs by 14 per cent earlier and another 2.5 per cent and they are advertising to increase electricity tariffs some more. That is not relief to the Ghanaian consumer. The Government has increased water tariffs; that is not relief to the Ghanaian consumer.

They are beginning to advertise that—And the majority of farmers who are cocoa farmers who benefit from cocoa and were hoping they will get some more based on the promises you have made—They may not be in a position to increase cocoa prices and give them more relief. So, Mr Speaker, yes, there have been developments on the Ghanaian economy, we expect that the Minister for Finance will appear shortly to provide some more details. But the reasons that are being given should be reasons that align more with the facts and less with the propaganda.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Deputy Minister for Roads and Highways (Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan): Thank you very much, Mr

Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by the Committee on Chairman of the Economy and Development. I will not repeat the fact that has been stated by many that, indeed, it was a thorough Statement, well-researched with facts.

Mr Speaker, I agree with my colleague, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, who says we should educate ourselves on the issues that have come up in contributions. Mr Speaker, and part of the education I want to note is that, sometimes, discipline can look like what he claimed as non-performance because it takes discipline to deny oneself of the ability to do. So, if one is not disciplined and they are not able to control their expenditure, then they run the risk of living deficits like those that we have inherited.

Mr Speaker, my Friend spoke about injections in the economy by the Bank of Ghana. The facts are that the IMF have indicated clearly that, in the last quarter of 2024 alone, when their Government was in power, the Bank of Ghana intervened with about US\$2 billion.

Mr Speaker, despite that US\$2 billion intervention, the cedi was exchanging at about GH¢16.00 to a dollar. That means that one cannot attribute the current good performance of the cedi to just a US\$1.4 billion intervention. If that were the case, the cedi would have been doing better when we had about US\$2 billion intervention in the last quarter of 2024.

Mr Speaker, he asked of where the intervention or the reserve is coming

from. It is coming from a reformed gold sector and that is a policy which is backed by good governance, where we now have the Ghana Gold Board ensuring that, in about just four months, the country is able to raise US\$2.7 billion. That is where an intervention can come from, but, again, I want to repeat that that intervention alone is not enough to bring the cedi to GH¢10 as it is trading to the dollar. If that were the case, it would have been better in 2024 when, in the last quarter, the Bank of Ghana intervened by over US\$2 billion.

Mr Speaker, the economy is something that we all live. It is simple and it is basic. Only last week, Mr Speaker, I was in my constituency. One branch chairman of mine came to a base where we were seated. He parked his motorbike and decided not to switch the engine off. When one of us called him and said, "Chief, please, turn off your engine". He said, "*Oh, aban papa aba* so, fuel has reduced and I do not care". Mr Speaker, to wit, that a good Government was in place and fuel prices have gone down, so he does not mind how much he pays for fuel now because it has reduced.

4.51p.m.

Mr Speaker, so when we speak of inflation, at the risk of contradicting my Colleagues who spoke earlier, it may be the case that, indeed, inflation coming down does not necessarily mean prices coming down. But in our circumstance today, the trending down of inflation, coupled with the improved exchange rate, has obviously led to reduction in prices of commodities on the market.

Only a couple of weeks ago, we celebrated Eid in this country. Before the current economic transformation that we are experiencing, we had Eid-ul Fitr in the early part of this year. As we all do, supporting our constituents, after Ramadan, during Eid-ul Fitr, I bought a bag of rice for GH¢620 in Tamale, just to support constituents. Mr Speaker, ask me how much I bought a bag of rice for only a couple of weeks ago when we had Eid-ul Adha. It was about GH¢400 for the same bag. These are facts.

Mr Speaker, yes, inflation trending down may not necessarily mean prices are coming down, but I am saying that we cannot run away from the fact that, today, because it is coupled with the improved exchange rate situation, we even have companies running *ya ti so ho* promotions across the country. They are telling us in their adverts that they are reducing prices because the cedi is becoming strong. It is on our radio and television stations today. We cannot run away from these facts. Fuel prices have reduced. Fuel that used to be sold at about GH¢14 per litre is now being sold below GH¢12 per litre. Transport fares have reduced. In the food sector, I just gave you an example of rice.

Mr Speaker, I commend the maker of the Statement for stating nothing but facts. I hope that moving forward, the conversations here will guide us to determine the roles each of us have to play to continue to sustain this growth for the benefit of all Ghanaians.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, I will come to the Leadership or you

would still want me to take one contribution from each Side? All right. Then, it is obvious that would be the Hon Members for Kwabre East and Essikadu-Ketan. Let me start with the Hon Member for Kwabre East.

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East):

Mr Speaker, it is an undeniable fact that the figures have reduced. That on paper, the exchange rate or the cedi has appreciated. Today, BoG is quoting the cedi to dollar at GH¢10.39 and GH¢10.4. We should ask ourselves that if we go to a bank today to get dollars, at what rate are they going to give to us? If one goes to the bank today to get dollars to do business, would they receive the quantity of dollars they need to do their business?

Today, the dollar is in high demand, but if one goes on the ground to look for dollars to trade, they would not get it. Do you know where one can get the dollar? Abotsi has the dollar, but the dollar is going for between GH¢13.00 to GH¢13.3 at the Abotsi centre. How is it that the banks do not have the dollar, but Abotsi has it? Today, BoG has the rate, but Abotsi has the dollar. What are we doing to ourselves as a country?

We cannot continue on this charade and continue to put things on paper, but when it comes to the reality, it is non-existent. We cannot do that. We need to be honest with ourselves. This facade of putting out a good dollar rate, but in reality, on the ground, it is different, we need to depart from it and do the right things for this country.

Mr Speaker, today, if one wants a dollar, the maximum amount one can get from a bank or forex bureau would be about US\$20,000, maximum. I am telling the House that if we go to the bank today, we might not even get US\$20,000. Just walk down to the bank—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You mean US\$20,000?

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Mr Speaker, US\$20,000 is the maximum you will get from a bank. One will not get the maximum that they need to trade, but we are here saying the dollar is at GH¢10.34 and GH¢10.4. We need to be honest with ourselves in this country.

Mr Speaker, again, we know that a few months ago, COCOBOD received about US\$1.8 billion. All this money has been injected into the economy and where did this US\$1.8 billion come from? The majority of cocoa that is bought is bought within the main crop, which is from October to December and even sometimes, early January, but October to December is where the majority is bought.

Last year, who was in power from October to December? The New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government bought majority of the cocoa, kept it and shipped it, which is why the US\$1.8 billion came into the economy to boost it. So, when they are giving credit, they should give credit where credit is due.

Today, they are mentioning that the economy is boosting. The four-month

import cover that he touted that it is being projected that we will get, how many months of import cover did the previous Government leave? It is also four months, so what are they doing? If they are repeating the four months and clapping for themselves, what are they doing? They are not doing anything,

Mr Speaker, Hon Suhuyini mentioned the Gold Board. Previously, when the Gold Board was not there, a pound of gold was sold at around GH¢12,000. Today, because of the Gold Board, the gold dealers are receiving only GH¢8,000. That is about 33 per cent short of what they were receiving. So, their purchasing power has rather reduced.

What is happening here? We are touting ourselves and putting things on paper and we say, we are doing well? Meanwhile, the people are suffering on the ground because they are receiving less money than they used to. We are saying that inflation has gone down. Has it reflected in the pockets of the ordinary Ghanaian? No, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I am saying that we should be honest with ourselves. My senior Colleague mentioned fiscal discipline. We were here when he said the district assemblies have not received their share of the Common Fund and they said it is not true. Is it the case that they are doing selective justice? Are they paying the district assemblies of the Majority and not paying that of the Minority? If that is the case, they should let us know because

I have not received it and my Hon senior Member has not received it.

No one on the Minority Side has received their share of the Common Fund, but the Majority Side said they have received theirs. Is it something that they are just saying to while away time and to create the impression that things are going on well? Mr Speaker, the sweetness of the pudding is in the eating; let them do things right and we will fill it in our pockets.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Prof Ayensu-Danquah?

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu-Ketan): Mr Speaker, I stand on a point of correction before I would like to contribute to the Statement. Mr Speaker, the Statement made by the Hon Minority Leader, respectfully, I think it is quite offensive. There is only 14 per cent of women in this House. Some of the Statements he made would also be in the *Hansard*. I stand here and speak on behalf of the women—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Prof Ayensu-Danquah, I have given you the floor; kindly contribute to the Statement.

5.01 p.m.

Prof Ayensu-Danquah: But before I contribute to the Statement, Mr Speaker, I would like to very much have that part of the discussion expunged because I was being attacked when I had not said a

word. I was just standing up and waiting to catch your eye. Mr Speaker, it makes it very difficult for the women —There is only 14 per cent of women in this House. So, when we stand to speak, and we get veiled threats and also passive-aggressive behaviours towards us, Mr Speaker, it makes it very difficult for us to speak. So, Mr Speaker, I really respectfully want to put this on record that I did not provoke that comment, and I also feel offended by it because I did nothing to deserve that.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Let me come to the Leadership.

Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Hon Member, we are going to have another Statement, then you contribute, please.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me commend our Colleague who chairs the Committee on Economy and Development, Dr Eric Afful, for bringing this Statement to the fore for all of us to comment upon.

Mr Speaker, this five-page document which he read, I have had the opportunity of going through it, and I must admit that it has taken a great deal of industry to produce this. I would want to commend him and add my voice to earlier speakers who encouraged other Committee leaders to, from time to time, come up with Statements regarding their sector. It

is good for us as a House to discuss some of these things from time to time.

Mr Speaker, let me set off, by way of my comments, with a quote from him at the last page of his Statement, the last but one paragraph, and I quote:

“Mr Speaker, due to the current performance of the economy, the Switzerland Government has awarded a grant of US\$77 million to support the development of a resilient and forward-looking economy of Ghana. Switzerland has pledged its support to Ghana through economy, trade, governance, democracy, peace and security, environment and climate change, as well as sustainable development”.

Mr Speaker, while the issue of US\$77 million grant is a fact, my question is, how did the Swiss Government generate this wealth? Through taxes. Can we do the same so that we do not depend on them for said grants? Because even if it is a grant, it is not for free. You still have to pay. So, Mr Speaker, the world has got to a stage where many countries are now looking at supporting their own citizens rather than engaging in external financial support to countries that may depend on them for budgetary support.

Mr Speaker, it is true that certain statistics are showing some positive signs. My concern is how to sustain these positive data that we are seeing. How do we sustain them?

Mr Speaker, one, as a country, we must change our attitude. We have a

huge attitudinal deficit. Many of our compatriots, when they benefit from initiatives of governments, they see it as a freebie. In the end, we the politicians play politics with this, and it becomes a burden on the country, and they go scot-free. The time has come, in my very humble view, for us to ensure a national dialogue, to chart a new path, and begin a new conversation that would help change the attitude of the very people who elect us into this Chamber.

Mr Speaker, if, as political leaders, we do not come together to identify the areas of the economy that affect the very foundation of our country, trust me, our democracy may not be there for us to benefit from. The attitude of our own people must change. Mr Speaker, I am not shy to cite some examples of interventions by governments, that have gone waste. Let us go back to former President Rawlings' Poverty Alleviation Fund; those who benefited, did they pay? Kufuor came, he continued. Kufuor started the Microfinance and Small Loans Centre (MASLOC), Prof Mills continued MASLOC. President Mahama, Chapter 1, continued MASLOC. Akufo-Addo continued MASLOC and even introduced the National Entrepreneurship & Innovation Programme (NEIP). How many people benefited and paid?

We buy them the tractors and the *aboboyas*; they take the money, do we pursue? If they do not pay, and because of politics, we also do not pursue because we want them to vote for us again and there is no positive attitude, Mr Speaker, this country will stagnate. It will not go

anywhere. Look at the energy sector crisis we are facing.

I was privileged to have chaired the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG)'s board for some few months. And Mr Speaker, if you see the challenge there, moneys that Government would have to use for development, it is using that same money to pay for electricity that people have enjoyed and are refusing to pay. How many companies are paying ECG bills? Even some of their prepaid metres have expired. People consume power because the metre is not reading. I believe that the political leaders of Ghana today must see this as a real threat to democracy. Because looking at the trend in global politics, nobody is ready to bring us their tax money to develop our country when we can deal with some inefficiencies in our system ourselves. So, I am saying that if we can sustain the economy with the information we have today, one of the things we should do as a country is to pursue a robust reform. For instance, in the energy sector, particularly, ECG, so that all leakages are addressed. Then people will not push Government to say that the only way is to tax the people. Then that also becomes politics. Is that what we want? Mr Speaker, let us change our attitude on some of these things.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of *galamsey*, until we begin a national dialogue, beginning in this very Chamber, that the NDC and the NPP understand that *galamsey* is a threat to our very existence, so that we communicate that with one voice to our people, Mr Speaker, we will be

pretending to be solving the problem. Every election cycle, somebody will promise to do this to win votes; soon thereafter, it will come and haunt us. Our Side will not be to obstruct Government; our Side is ready to constructively critique, but also to sit on the table with the Government and look at these national issues.

The West African sub-region is melting because they took some of these things for granted. Ghana, perhaps, is the only serious democracy standing, but we have these challenges there. Mr Speaker, if we do not deal with this *galamsey* thing — money is getting into the hands of people and people are destroying the environment. In the long run, it is this same economy that it would affect.

5.11 p.m.

How do you sustain your economy when some environmental factors are affecting the economy and it is hand-to-mouth? Mr Speaker, look at the issue of crop production—food. Reading this Statement, it is talking about some economic gains, but indeed, the poor farmer in Bawku, Hamile, Gyenyase in Effutu and Hohoe, are they getting the needed support?

Mr Speaker, it is when we invest in agriculture that we can sustain an economy. If we are not investing in these areas, but are talking about some six months successes, then, after everything comes to square one, do we go back to the IMF begging? Today, the District Road Improvement Programme (DRIP) machines that are supposed to be here for

our roads, some people are using it for *galamsey* and there is no authority to even reprimand. There is impunity because they come and tell us that they voted for us, so we should allow them to do whatever. No!

Mr Speaker, what is the strength or the authority of the Ghanaian politician? I am happy that Government intends to roll out a lot of incentives to support the private sector including this *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* Project. However, Mr Speaker, my question is what support systems have we put in place to ensure that these investments when they go, they come? That should be the focus of the discussion if we are talking about the economy. As Ghanaian politicians, we should not allow things to implode, it may be too quicker than we expect. It can just be one morning and the very people that we failed to discuss the challenges with will say you have failed.

Mr Speaker, look at the turn out in the 2024 election, a whole Greater Accra where we do a lot of the political activism had a 55 per cent turn up. It should tell us that the people are beginning to get fed up with us, to say that what are we doing; they can no longer trust us. Look at the Ablekuma North election, we were told that 6000 voters were in the 19 polling stations. If we add the figures that we saw, at least those ones that were officially announced, it was almost like 2000. What it means is that it is just around 35 per cent that decided to come out and vote with all the noise. It tells us that the

citizens are losing trust. They do not have confidence in us, and Mr Speaker, we must wake up. We must limit the politicking, the partisanship, and at least dialogue on critical issues. It is not enough to say that the Government has done so well. I am not here to do any partisan politics—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, thank you very much.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I will conclude with respect. I am not taking this Statement with a partisan eye; I am happy with that courage in bringing it up. But I am asking that if we do not do all the things that I have raised and we do not get a bi partisan support to move our country forward and we continue in the path that we are all seeing with our eyes, how do we sustain the economy and our democracy?

I, therefore, would conclude by saying that we should use this Statement by Dr Eric Afful—He says that it is an honorary doctorate, these days that Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) is all over the place—*[Laughter]*—I do not want—Mr Speaker, that day I enquired from him because he is my friend, so I first asked him “Bro is this honorary” and he said “Yes, it is honorary”. Mr Speaker, our respected Colleague, Dr Eric Afful, honorary doctorate, is the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am being corrected and I like to be corrected. My Hon Colleagues behind are saying that if it is honorary then I cannot say doctor, so I should just say Mr Eric Afful. How then does he take— Mr Speaker, I do not want controversy. It is an honorary doctorate, so if it is an honorary doctorate, he cannot use the title. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, it is—The Hon Member has just come from his Ministry and he wants to come and create problems. It is part “Statement on the Highlight of Positive Trends of the Economy of Ghana by Hon Dr”—Hon Emmanuel, please it is Hon Dr Eric.

I am saying that our Colleague Hon Dr Eric Afful—Well, this has not been amended, I would want to rely on the document I have here.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, at least he has set the pace, let us move in that direction. I am happy that Hon Mahama Ayariga, Leader of Government Business, has entered the Chamber. Mr Speaker, he has come at the right time and I would want to invite him to begin that national dialogue in this very House. He should start it; we will support him because there are security issues affecting our country. There are key areas that with one voice if we educate our people, talk to them and rationalise, it is not about NDC or NPP. It is about the system that we are all running—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if we come together, Ghana would benefit. I thank you so much for the opportunity, Mr Speaker. Dr Eric Afful, thank you so much too.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Majority Leadership?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I would add my voice to commend Dr Eric Afful for the Statement he made today. Mr Speaker, this should be something that all Chairpersons of Committees should emulate in leading some of the discussions we have in the House with the areas that they chair.

Mr Speaker, it is a very important and timely. Mr Speaker, something is happening in this country that, maybe, some have not paid attention to. People are wondering why within six months or so of a government things seem to have dramatically improved. Mr Speaker, you hear people say that this is not going to last or this is just to pull wool over our eyes, without critically looking at what is happening. When we make a Statement—I need to thank my Hon Minority Leader, Osahen Afenyo-Markin, in fact, when one is given a title, one must use it and I am glad he uses his.

Mr Speaker, Ghana has been producing gold for over 100 years, yet we have never been in control of our gold. Different governments have come and gone, but Ghana has never been in

control of the gold we produce which is our natural resource. We must commend the current government for coming up with this idea of GOLDBOD. The whole idea is for us to be able to take charge of the gold that we produce, so that it does not end up on the shelves of other countries to bag up their currencies.

5.23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, so we must commend the Government for this Ghana Gold Board (GoldBod) which is raking in money that is going to sustain our currency. I also admit that credit should also be given to the Government that started the Gold Purchasing Programme. Mr Speaker, the Gold Purchasing Programme, again, was something that was done at the eleventh hour because, in Ghana, we have been producing gold for many years. All the countries that we measure ourselves with, in terms of our currency weight, have their currencies backed by gold.

But a Ghana that produces the gold does not back its currency with gold. And how come or how can we then have a currency that is strong and sustainable? So, it is a good idea that we introduced the GoldBod. But it is also good that the current Government has maintained that policy and intensified it. It is for that simple reason, not a record sign, that the cedi will continue to appreciate and stabilise. We do not actually need intervention anymore going forward. When currency of a country is stable and not fluctuating, it does not need intervention from the central bank. So, its reserve will be kept in the bank and it

can always boast off between four and six months of import cover.

So, it is not anything that they would say nobody is doing anything. Somebody is doing something. Because if we do not continue to buy the gold and build a gold reserve, Great Britain, United Kingdom and United States of America and other countries in Europe would build gold reserves. But Ghana that produces the gold does not have any gold reserve.

One cannot understand that we have not done that for all these years and we have suffered generation after generation. It is important that the Government of today has introduced this GoldBod and it is important, though even if it was eleventh hour, for the previous Government to start the gold purchasing, for this Government to intensify it. So, anybody who thinks that our currency will be going back to the old days, then they do not know exactly what is happening in this country.

A small tweaking that this country has done is going to keep us safe, strong, and stable and we would not have all the problems that we have had in the past if we do not mess these things up. So, these are the things that we should actually wake up to and see how we can help this Government do this and do it better and for future generations to continue, so that our currency will be strong and we will have the purchasing power. In Economics, basically, all the indices you have mentioned here and the numbers we are giving are all interlinked. So, if one thing is doing well, all the others naturally, a domino effect, will also do

well. So, we need not understand why inflation is doing better. If inflation is doing better, it is simply because the inflation on food is actually going down. Interest rates and all the other things we can talk about.

So, when we make a Statement, as intellectual as this Statement is, with the fact that it has, let us look at the fact and not play politics with some of these things and look at giving credit where credit is due and not to say that this Government is not doing anything. This Government is doing something that this country has never done for 70 years. Let us think about it and that is why we are where we are today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Let us look at the other things and see how we can make this country better for all of us rather than making points that does not help the development of this country.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the maker of this Statement again and I thank you very much for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

I will now invite Hon Kofi Obiri Yeboah to make his Statement. I think that Statement was earlier placed on hold because we wanted the Minister to be here to listen to the Statement. So, now, I have seen the Minister and his Deputy.

Hon Member for Subin, the floor is yours now.

Embargo on Transactions Involving State and Public Lands

Mr Kofi Obiri Yeboah (NPP — Subin): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to speak on this matter of urgent public importance concerning the embargo placed on the Lands Commission halting the sale, lease and processing of transactions involving state and public lands.

Mr Speaker, upon assumption of office, the President, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, by a letter dated 10th January 2025, directed the Lands Commission to halt the sale, leasing and processing of all state and public lands. Mr Speaker, although the decision of the President may aim at safeguarding public lands for the benefit of Ghanaians, this directive may also affect individuals, corporate entities which may have legitimately acquired interest in these lands. For instance, Mr Speaker, there are lands within the Osu Mantse layout that were vested in the state, but, subsequently, individuals and corporate entities acquired interest in same, upon application to the Lands Commission.

Mr Speaker, as you may be aware, the composition of the Lands Commission Board provided under Article 259 of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana comprises a chairman who is neither a Minister nor Deputy Minister and representative of various bodies, including the National House of Chiefs, the Ghana Bar Association, the Ghana

Institution of Surveyors, the National Association of Farmers and Fishermen, *inter alia*.

Mr Speaker, it is imperative to know that before one may acquire an interest in State lands, he or she may have gone through a rigorous process as structured by law and practice. Mr Speaker, although the directives by the President to halt all state transactions may have been issued with good intentions, it may pose serious challenges. Among the challenges I envisage include disruption to land registration processes.

Registration of state-owned lands, such as the Osu Mantse layout, which are often owned by individuals and corporate entities, are now in limbo. This directive means that individuals seeking to perfect or register their lands with the Lands Commission are unable to proceed. This creates uncertainty and stagnation in land administration, a critical sector in the economy of Ghana.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, it deprives the private investor, both individuals and corporate bodies to use their legally acquired lands to secure loans from the bank. If, indeed, the Government thinks that the private sector is the engine of growth, then the Government, as a matter of urgency, should lift the ban.

Also, there will be an impact on financial transactions. Mr Speaker, individuals and corporate entities which may have acquired interest in state lands and use same as security for loans from financial institutions will face difficulties as they may not be able to assign their

interest in such lands to the financing institutions. This restriction could lead to defaults on obligations.

Again, there will be an impact on consolidated funds.

5.31 p.m.

Impact on Consolidated Fund.

Mr Speaker, revenue generated by the Lands Commission through stamp duties, consent fees, lease preparation fees, premium costs and all charges as embedded in offer letters will by virtue of these directives, become non-existent. This revenue loss will adversely impact the Consolidated Fund, thereby affecting Government budgets. The Lands Commission is said to be the second source of revenue for Government in terms of non-tax revenue after the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA)

Impact on Joint Venture Agreements

Mr Speaker, this directive will also affect joint venture agreements between individuals or corporate entities and the state, which were entered into prior to the issuance of these directives. In the quest of Government to safeguard state property, especially the eminent domain ones, one of the tools or methods that successive Governments have deployed is joint venture agreements with individuals and corporate entities.

Mr Speaker, these types of agreements do inure to the benefit of the state in that such arrangements, more often than not, may come at no direct

cost to the state. In most of these transactions, the private parties to the agreement are required by the Government to build executive townhouses to accommodate Ministers and other top government officials using their own resources. The Government in turn, pays back by offering them lands that are termed “demise land”.

Mr Speaker, these individuals or corporate entities may have performed their obligations under the joint venture agreements, awaiting the Lands Commission to engross leases in their favour. With this directive, however, the Lands Commission is estopped from performing their duties under these agreements.

If care is not taken, the state will be saddled with lots of court actions and judgement debts. As we speak, several individuals and corporate entities have secured court judgement in respect of state lands against the Lands Commission. The Lands Commission, however, is unable to comply with the court judgement as a result of these directives.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I strongly believe that while decisive measures are sometimes necessary for governance, a blanket halt on all state transactions, without considering its ripple effects on critical sectors such as land administration and financing, is counterproductive. It is crucial that the directive be reviewed to allow for essential land transactions, especially those already in process.

The Government must strike a balance between enforcing policies and maintaining the smooth functioning of critical institutions like the Lands Commission, which imparts the livelihoods of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, I am grateful for this opportunity and Subin Constituency is grateful. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, I will give you the opportunity. If you could sit and listen to other comments before you take your bite.

Yes, Ing Surv Lukutor?

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Mr Speaker, I would like to commend my Colleague for the Statement he has ably made. I want to put on record that inasmuch as he has tried to draw our attention to some of the issues that may be worrying at this moment, he failed to advert our minds to the basic reasons the President issued this ban.

Now, the number one reason for which the President issued the ban is to ensure that we safeguard public lands. I remember in 2017 thereabouts, the former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, then Hon Peter John Amewu, said that state lands were being sold like *kelewele* in the market. Inasmuch as he attracted a lot of laughter from the populace, it was like lands were just being sold without recourse to the rules and regulations that governed them.

Unfortunately, people who were given land prior to their coming were such that even now, some of them have not got their land. I happened to serve on the Lands Commission Board then and even when they were in Government, I had the opportunity to serve under the Ghana Institution of Surveyors as a Board Member, so the things that happened within this Lands Commission are such that rules and regulations were not observed.

For instance, one of the rules is that if it is a residential land, no one should have more than one plot. The question comes to play, what is the definition of one plot of land? One plot of land can be 0.16 of an acre or 0.18 of an acre, or 0.23 of an acre, or even 0.43 of an acre. So, that is the discretion some of our administrators have to “create loot and share” and these are the very things we understood were going on in the land administration system, which calls for some of these stringent measures to be put in place.

We also want to review and have accountability for our state lands. As stated in the ORAL document, most of our lands were looted. So Government, in its wisdom, wants to ensure that we investigate and understand the basis for the allocation of some of these lands.

We also want to prevent irregularities, that is to curb and prevent corruption and improve efficiency across public institutions. The Lands Commission is one of the very public institutions that sometimes, some of us who play within the system, when people

describe, makes one want to leave the system because it looks as if it is a citadel of corruption. Most of our issues that we heard in the past were based on this fact that lands were sold just anyhow. So I support the President when he says that we should allow a lot of investigation into the system to get where there were irregularities.

There were a lot of land sale regulations that were so open and it was up to the discretion of whoever was granting the land. We are saying that we want to look into these situations and ensure that where we had to rehash or regularise some of these systems, we do it to curb the over-dependence on discretion on the authorities or the people who matter in this situation.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Ing Surv Lukutor: I believe that the Executive Secretary of the Lands Commission was appointed exactly on 14th April, 2025, about four months down the line. I am not sure that he would have been able to finish with the issues that concern the allocation of these lands.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Lukutor.

Ing Surv Lukutor: Is the Member saying that because people are losing their value, they should be allowed to go through the system of registration without due recourse to what we want to do to ensure that we nip these situations in the bud?

Mr Speaker, I thank you so much, but I wish that he does better by bringing out to the public the things that caused the President, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, to put a ban rather than the causes and the consequences he thinks that people are suffering due to this.

I thank you very much for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Are you saying that the consequences are not important?

Ing Surv Lukutor: Mr Speaker, I am not saying the consequences are not important.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The reason is important as well as the consequences.

Ing Surv Lukutor: Something might have caused somebody to put a situation in place. So, if he just talks about the consequences without talking about what really is causing whatever is happening — Isaac Newton says, action and reaction are equal and opposite, is that not it?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Thank you.

Yes, Hon Member for Odotobri?

Mr Anthony Mmieh (NPP — Odotobri): Mr Speaker, in the first place, I would like to commend the Hon Member for Subin for his delivery.

Mr Speaker, it has been over seven months since this embargo was placed on the sale, leasing, as well as all transactions affecting Government lands. It started off by one.

5.43 p.m.

I would like to enumerate it. It started off by:

First, the Executive Director was asked to present a report on all recent transactions. In the same letter dated 10th January, 2025, he was also asked to present a comprehensive review of the current framework which the Lands Commission goes by. Subsequent to these two directives, there was a more serious one: directing the Lands Commission not to process any transaction dated after 2017. The Government knows why they did that, which I believe Ghanaians would want to know.

Mr Speaker, my concern is that it is a very well-known fact that the Lands Commission generates a lot of money for the businesses of this Government. We have individuals, organisations, *et cetera* who have acquired lands, completed buildings, occupied their premises, but do not pay rent, because according to the letter dated 10th January 2025, they were not supposed to be doing any business regarding transactions dated 2017 and beyond.

Mr Speaker, apart from that, no stamp duty is being generated, but we are aware that every government requires a

lot of money, a great deal of money, to be able to do its business.

Mr Speaker, that aside, we all know the problem in Accra. There are problems with family lands, stool lands, and a lot of people are comfortable acquiring government lands because of these problems. Not to forget about investors, and this is also affecting the interest of investors in doing business in Ghana. For seven months now, no businessman or business entity can acquire government land. If even one acquired it, one cannot go ahead to process documentation on said land. We would have to look at this critically. Seven months is too much. Everybody is suffering; the individual is suffering, and institutions are suffering.

I would urge the Government to expedite action on this, so that it would serve as a deterrent to those who have committed crimes. Then again, for those who have acquired lands genuinely, they can pay the necessary statutory fees, duties, *et cetera* for the Government to earn money to do its business. Then the foreign investors, can also have confidence in our system again, acquire lands, and come and do their business.

Mr Speaker, I am grateful.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Education?

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by Mr Kofi Obiri Yeboah. I do not know if I

have his permission to call him *Osikani*, as he was popularly referred to in Commonwealth Hall during our days at the University of Ghana. He was my campaign manager.

Mr Speaker, on the larger issue, I am sure the Hon Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources will provide policy guidance. But to assure the maker of the Statement, President Mahama is a law-abiding President of the Republic. Yes, it is true that he issued a directive on the 10th January, 2025, to sanitise land acquisition in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, those who lawfully and genuinely acquired their lands should not worry about the consequence of these directives. What the President sought to do was to have first-hand information on who got what, when, how, and for how much.

Mr Speaker, and then to specifically deal with those who, in the name of influence and authority, are grabbing public lands against the public interest and not even acquiring land. Mr Speaker, may I with respect refer you to Article 257 of the Constitution and it says:

“All public lands in Ghana shall be vested in the President on behalf of, and in trust for, the people of Ghana.”

Mr Speaker, it imposes a fiduciary responsibility on the President that tomorrow, he should be able to account to the Ghanaian people how public lands were managed in Ghana under his watch, having assumed office as President of the Republic. The President is well aware

that we would need land for farming and we would need land for investment. In fact, the President thinks that there must be a rapid response to people who stand in the way of foreign investors who come into Ghana to acquire land in order that we can accelerate how attractive Ghana can be in respect of foreign direct investment.

Mr Speaker, in concluding, we also know, that in Ghana, people have taken advantage of this acquisition of public lands. Hon Kofi should look at Article 20 very well. If for instance, he acquires a land for public purpose, and he has not used it for the public purpose, the land must go back to its original owners. That has not happened in many instances.

Mr Speaker, to assure my Colleague, the directive of the President was to have first-hand information on how public lands have been managed over the last eight years, and who took undue advantage of this in order that he can provide correctional measures as the person to whom this land is vested? So, Hon Kofi should be assured that those who are doing legitimate business and want to acquire land for the purpose of business, are not the target of the directive of the President. His target is the looters of land in the name of influence. How can one acquire a school park or a school building or a school land for the purpose of acquiring a public land?

Mr Speaker, elsewhere, the law even on Ashanti lands is different. The law on Upper-East lands is different. The laws in other jurisdictions are different.

Mr Speaker, I am sure the Minister for Lands and Natural resources will provide an appropriate response. The President acted lawfully within his mandate in order to sanitise the acquisition of lands in Ghana and to stop the looting of public lands in the name of public influence. So, he has accordingly directed that no Minister under his watch should be associated with the acquisition of any public lands. I am sure we would oblige him in order that we help him achieve their sanity.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Suame?

Mr John Darko (NPP — Suame): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by my Brother, the MP for Subin, Mr Kofi Obiri Yeboah.

Mr Speaker, his Statement has brought up important issues happening in the land administration sector. In this country, at least in Accra, sometimes it takes five to six years to register lands.

5.51 p.m.

Mr Speaker, you know that in this country, or at least in Accra, it takes five to six years to register a land. So, the Policy by His Excellency the President, in my view, has put an undue burden on the Lands Commission and the people of Ghana. As I already said, Mr Speaker, it takes so much time to register a land in

Ghana, so for the President to maintain this Policy for the past seven months, without review, means that now the time for registration of lands is going to go way up. Is that what we want as a country that if you buy a land and want to register, it would take you six to eight years?

Mr Speaker, I am aware and I have clients who have lands purchased from private individuals and they are supposed to transfer their titles to another private people even though the lands were originally government or public lands, and because of this Policy, they are unable to register or get their titles. Mr Speaker, this is a worrisome situation and I believe that the Minister should be able to tell us when the government intends to review this Policy.

The Policy as it is right now, in my view, Mr Speaker, with respect, I believe was not properly thought through. If it were, Mr Speaker, timelines would have been given. For instance, the President would have said that he is putting this embargo for three months for a review to be done. When embargo was placed, it did not give timelines. So, the people of Ghana do not know how long this embargo is going to take before it is reviewed, especially those who are registering lands.

Mr Speaker, this is a very important Statement, and I believe every Member in this House should support the Statement ably made by my Brother, especially Mr Speaker, as it deals with the time within which registration of land is done.

Mr Speaker, without more, I thank you for the opportunity, and I yield the floor.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me go to Tema West before I come to you.

Mr James Enu (NDC — Tema West): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Let me start by thanking the maker of the Statement for this very important Statement to the House. Let me also say that I want to associate myself with the submissions that were made by the Hon Minister for Education.

Indeed, this directive by the President was triggered by certain circumstances. We witnessed what we call the state capture, particularly in Tema West. We had a situation where football parks and markets were being sold out under very bizarre circumstances. And if you look at a place like the Ramsar Site, it has been completely sold out to the extent that recently there were some demolitions around the area and it came out clearly that people were even building in the centre of the Ramsar site because all these places were sold out. So, it was important for such a directive to come to sanitise the system. I believe that by so doing, we will ensure that all the lands that were acquired under the wrong circumstances can be revoked and reverted to the state.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Can I revert to Leadership?

Let me take the Minister first before I come to you or the other way round?

Yes, Minister. I think if you have listened to the Statement, and you have listened to your Colleagues.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi): Mr Speaker, I am very grateful for this opportunity to contribute to this Statement made by my good Friend, Hon Kofi Obiri Yeboah on this very important subject matter.

Mr Speaker, listening to him, I asked myself whether this was the right time to read this Statement, given the fact that from where I sit, I have a lot of information. But I will be measured because if I were to come out with detailed information that I have with respect to land sales, especially government land sales, I am sure my Brother would have decided that he would wait and make this Statement another time.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency the President acted lawfully, and like my hardworking Minister for Education stated, he acted within the law. I thought that Hon Colleague would be praising the President, because in his own Statement, he said that the President did what he did in order to safeguard government lands. That is an admission that indeed what he has done is the right thing. I know him as a lawyer—A land lawyer, and I know he has so much interest in issues that have to do with land, and so I am not surprised he came out with this Statement. But let me just say this, that even within this House,

especially with reference to Hon Stephen Amoah, who made a public Statement that he is appealing to the President and this government to ensure that a land that was taken away from schools in the Ashanti Region be reverted to the schools. This is a Deputy Minister who served in the previous administration for some number of years. I know he could not talk while his government was in power, but he was bold enough to call on the President to ensure that this land is given back to the school. It tells you that indeed there is a problem. It tells you that there is the need for the President to investigate the sale of government lands over this period.

I heard somebody asking why 2017 to date? Under the previous administration, there was a committee that investigated the sale of land between a certain period ending in 2016. So, there would be no need for you to go back and do investigation when those investigations have already been done. We are also told that the government is going to lose revenue because people who are now willing to pay their taxes are not paying. This does not mean that when the ban is lifted, they will not pay those monies. So, no money is going to be lost. It is important to also put this on record.

The maker of the Statement said that some people legitimately acquired their lands. Let us advert our minds to the very law that gives the right for us to be able to acquire such lands as individuals or as corporate organisations and that law is the State Land Act, 1962 (Act 125). The Act came with it, State Lands

Regulations, 1962 (L.I. 230) and in that LI, there is a form called Form 5. The Hon Member should take a look at the requirements of that form very well. Let me mention some of the requirements: One, the applicant must provide his bank statement; two, the applicant must provide two passport-sized pictures; the applicant must also state his source of funding to develop the land; the applicant cannot also acquire more than two plots. There are instances where people have plots in Ashaiman, government land in Osu and everywhere.

6.01 p.m.

These are the reasons for the need for us to investigate the sale of government lands.

Mr Speaker, let me also say that the President has put in place a very strong bipartisan committee. Let me announce to the House that the committee is made up of people like Prof Kwame Gyan and I know you know him very well. We have Prof Yakubu Banor and Rev Lawrence Tetteh serving on this committee. We also have Dr Sepran at the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources serving on this committee.

It tells us that the President means business. The President wants to interrogate and assess the way lands were sold in this country within this period, so that he can account to the good people of Ghana for the stewardship they have given him within the period that he is supposed to govern.

Mr Speaker, let me also state that there were some government land arrangements. For instance, he made reference to the swap arrangement, where government land is given to private individuals, so they value the land and also provide some asset to the Government *in lieu* of the land that they have given to them. We have come to realise that there was no value for money for some of those lands. So, it is important to ensure that Ghanaians benefit from the very land that they bequeathed to us.

Very soon, the committee will come out with its findings. The President has given us up to the second week of August to submit our report. Once that is done, I can assure the House that the ban will be lifted and there will be policy guidelines. Also, if there is a need for some legislation to be made, we will do that in order to ensure that government or state lands are not abused in the way we are currently seeing it.

Indeed, there was a rush to register government lands in the last days of the previous Administration and the records are there. If we go to the Lands Commission, the number of applications that they saw within that short period is unimaginable. Why were they rushing to do it? Clearly, something went wrong somewhere.

Let me say that some people have called me, as the chairman of the Committee, that they were worried that, with the way we are going about this issue, how are they also going to get lands. I told them that this is a different

Administration; this is the Mahama-led Administration. It is not like the previous one, where people can acquire land anyhow. And for us, it is about Ghanaians and nothing. So, I have told those people that, very soon, there will be a policy guideline that will not allow people to acquire government land the way we saw it under the previous Administration.

Mr Speaker, let me end it here and assure the maker of the Statement that, very soon, the ban will be lifted and there will be a report. I am inviting him to appear before the committee. We are inviting so many people. And if he wants to give us some information, he is most welcome. We can arrange for him to come and provide us with the information he has.

Mr Speaker, when I spoke about Dr Stephen Amoah that he made a call to the President and for that matter, to the Ministry, that there are some lands that were acquired by the previous Administration and that those lands belong to schools, the Hon Minister said it here. School lands were acquired and given to private individuals. Now, if the school wants to expand, where do they go? So, I intend to invite Hon Stephen Amoah to also come and provide us with information, so that we can get that land back to the school. When we do that, then we will know that, indeed, we are resetting this country.

With this, Mr Speaker, I thank you.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, now let me come to Leadership.

Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for this opportunity. I want to commend the maker of this Statement, Lawyer Kofi Obiri Yeboah, who is well known in these land matters as an expert.

Mr Speaker, just as he captured in his Statement, he says that and I quote:

“Although the directive by the President to halt all state transactions may have been issued with good intentions, it may pose serious problems or challenges.”

Mr Speaker, I can understand where my Colleague is coming from; this is obviously not a bad step. But consequentially, what we have seen over the period is that lands which have been acquired by individuals who had to go through proper legal processes are being taken from them by all manner of people, including people now labelling themselves as National Security operatives. They enter into people's lands, in fact, including ones which have been registered and have been properly titled and forcefully take them. This brings about a lot of problems.

Mr Speaker, as I speak with you, there are individuals who are even now fighting chiefs to claim lands that belong to the Government just because of this directive. Mr Speaker, when we go to

Cantonments, Labone, and several other high-end areas, some of these lands have now become the lands of some traditional leaders. Now, what they say is that, since the President has given this directive, the lands have automatically reverted to them, causing a lot of problems.

Mr Speaker, land “guardism” is now on the rise— [**Some Hon Members:** Eii!]
—It is the order of the day. Mr Speaker, unless my Friends do not want to bear with me and to learn from me the truth. When we go to areas I have indicated *supra*, people go and say that—*[Interruption]*—It is all right to listen and learn—*[laughter]*—People go with all manner of forces to forcefully take lands from people. Besides that, there is also a problem that I have noticed with this directive. It is for the purposes of moving Ghana forward. If a person is given a directive and the directive only ends in 2016, obviously, there is a problem with that directive. Because state lands were given out in 2015, 2014 and 2013.

Mr Speaker, nobody is saying that they should not give the natural course of directives. But when they stop and we still find friends who can still go behind the scenes and have these lands registered, that is questionable. Does that make this directive a proper directive? This is what we have to ask ourselves. With that comes in witch-hunting because it is believed that if Hon Habib Iddrisu has one or Dr Mahama has one or I have one; then people will come after me, while the others can go and register. That is a problem.

I was expecting the Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to also tell us that, pursuant to the Constitution, I think Article 259, the Regional Lands Commissions have been commissioned. As we speak, I do not think there is any Regional Lands Commission that has been commissioned.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: For that one, I know that—

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, it is all right. If that is even the case—

Alhaji Suleman — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Do not worry, I will come to you.

Mr Shaib: The Hon Member should not worry. He can sit down. When I finish, he can make his corrections.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I will come to you, so do not worry.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, if the Regional Lands Commissions have even been commissioned, I have information, again, that where there are requirements, as stated by the Constitution, for instance, that the Ghana Bar Association has to have a representative, Mr Speaker, who is giving the name of the Ghana Bar Association representative to be a part of the commission? I am telling him on authority that the information that I have is not coming from—

6.13 p.m.

So, a lawyer who is supposed to be a representative on the Commission who is

supposed to be submitted by the Ghana Bar is not what is happening. I expect my Colleague, the Minister, to rather go and do a foolproof check to find out if the right people are the right people on the Commission.

Mr Speaker, that is the truth. We are doing all of this to ensure that the right things are done. I have followed this over the period as a former Commissioner and I know what I am saying.

Mr Speaker, with all this said, I want to thank you for the opportunity and I want to thank my Friend, Hon Obiri.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But Hon Jerry—Leader, I am coming. Are you saying that land registration is going on selectively?

Mr Shaib: Yes.

Mr Speaker, I am also saying that the members who are supposed to be from the committee for the Commission are being selected and they are not using the right channel.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Leader, before I come to you, let me give two minutes to the Deputy Minister to address some of these issues.

Alhaji Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I am very grateful for this opportunity to correct the records.

I am a bit surprised that this is coming from my very respected Second

Deputy Minority Whip. He contradicted himself. In one breadth, he said that he is not sure that the original Land Commission has been inaugurated. In another breadth, he is said that they have been integrated, but they have not used the right processes to select, especially, those who are supposed to represent the Ghana Bar Association.

Let me put it on record that the Ministry wrote letters to the various institutions and they have responded, selecting the people they wanted to represent them on the Board and we have all the letters. Tomorrow, God willing, at 1 o'clock, we are going to inaugurate the last Regional Board and that is the Greater Accra Regional Board. That is the last one. So, if he says that he is not sure that we have inaugurated them, I am putting it to him that we have inaugurated all of them, except Greater Accra, which is going to happen tomorrow.

Again, let me also say that all the allegations you made here are false, but because you are a Leader and I want to be very charitable because of where you sit— I do not want to destroy my personal relation with him, but I know that the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources is law-abiding and his Deputy Minister is following his footprints. So, we are not behaving like what happened under their Administration. There are records and if he wants, from here, he should follow me to the Ministry. I will show him letters from the various institutions, nominating the people they wanted to serve on the Boards. We are

not doing things like the way they did then. That is the difference.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Alhaji Sulemana: There is no selective registration. If he pushes this issue, we have to invite him to come and provide evidence of where he has seen Lands Commission disrespecting the directives and doing some selective registration. That is unfair and I think that it should not be coming from him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader?

Mr Nitiwul —*rose*—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I beg you, Leader, it did not come early. I mean, we have gone round and round. We have come to Leadership.

Mr Nitiwul: No, Mr Speaker, I give him all the reverence. I am not going to take—I was here when you said that it is the time of Leadership, so I do not intend to hijack the position of Leader. That is not it. I was only telling—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He is a former Leader, so let me give—

Mr Nitiwul: I was only telling my Colleague opposite who just finished speaking that if he is responding to a specific point that my Colleague made, which he said that the Commission in Accra has not been inaugurated—You responded—*[Interruption]*—Can I finish? But when you—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, order!

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, when he tries to cast aspersion on previous Governments, he leaves himself room for me to get up and speak back at him. Because he does not have any proof that the Commissions were not put in place and people were selling lands under the previous Government. If I ask him to prove it, he cannot prove it. He cannot prove that that was not done—*[Interruption]*—Excuse me. So, please, make your point, but do not say that they are not doing it like how others were doing it. It is wrong because he does not have any proof about it. The records are clear.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, please.

Mr Nitiwul: The records are clear. That any land that was sold or any land that was given out was done using due process. If he has a problem with it, he has set a committee to probe, let it come out with its reports, present it to the people of Ghana and let us all debate it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Mr Nitiwul: Today, he is no more in opposition, so he cannot do propaganda. He is a Minister. We can do even though we will not do. He is a Minister.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader of the House?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I think this is one of the very important Statements made in this House. It touches on one of the very important matters that border on accountability of public officers.

Mr Speaker, I was Minister more than eight years ago and I drive around property that I lived in that Colleague Ministers lived in. Today, I see almost all those properties pulled down and new buildings put up. It has become a practice for public officers when they occupy government bungalows, by the time they leave the government bungalows, they would have acquired the bungalow, either in their names or in the names of third parties. And it is not just elected public officers; it is also the senior civil servants and technocrats.

So, public officers, generally, lands that were acquired by Nkrumah and the colonial government for public infrastructure, we have made it a habit that, as for our generation, not only will we disappoint the future by not acquiring new lands, but even what has been bequeathed to us, we will make sure that they do not survive us. So, this is a very serious matter.

Mr Speaker, I think that, sometimes, we take certain matters lightly. But the public is watching. They know every inch of land in this country; they know which ones belong to the state. And when we steal those lands, they see and they know, so let us get serious.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, when you say, “When they steal”, I am in a difficulty. If the acquisition is not proper, that is fine, but when you say, “When they steal”—

Mr Ayariga: There is legal stealing and illegal stealing. Mr Speaker, I heard him. He said that we should come to the probe and prove that due process was not followed. The fact that someone followed due process does not mean that person did not steal public lands. The fact that someone went through due process does not mean that public land has not been stolen. There can be conspiracy to go through due process to steal public lands. It happens all the time, where public officers connive and go through due process to steal public land. That has happened.

6.31 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Have you seen the Minister for Education is looking at you? *[Laughter]*

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, yes, I went to the School of Law. But I am saying that public officers will conspire to go through due process to steal public lands. Mr Speaker, that is what is happening. We are stealing public lands and this became a major campaign issue. Where Ga communities were complaining about their lands which were taken from them to establish the capital city. Now, we say we do not need those lands and we are not returning it to the Ga people. We are finding ways and means of going through due process to take the lands for ourselves.

So, it is a big issue and the Ga people have been marginalised and they are living just along the coast. The very expensive parts of the city: Roman Ridge, Cantonments, Airport Residential area, *et cetera* are far beyond their means. Acquiring state lands have become a mechanism of corruption because we undervalue the lands; we acquire the lands, then we sell them for their real values and then we cream off the difference. It is a clear case of stealing.

Mr Speaker, if we take the sales at the point where the property was being passed from the state to the private person and now go to the market and check the value of the same land, the difference is ridiculous. An acre of land that costs millions of dollars will be sold to individuals at just a few hundred thousand Ghana cedis and, immediately, they will go and flip it. That is clear corruption. This is what President John Dramani Mahama has decided that he will put an end to and that is the basis of the directive that was given. So, I am surprised that anybody on this Side will actually be discussing this matter. We would have just kept quiet because if we really go into the records and we really pursue the matter, there will be issues.

Mr Speaker, so, I think that we should be commending the President for the boldness. Why? Those who were there and were rushing to sell, it is not just that they are the ones who know money or know how to acquire property. The President has brought a team into Government by stopping the transactions. The manner in which he

sent a clear signal to his own team that this is not something he will tolerate.

We are not talking about those who were selling left and right and then somebody said he was not saying they should not sell. But before they sell, they should pass it through him. Have they forgotten so soon? —[*Laughter*]— that a certain President said they should seek clearance from him before selling— [Interruption]— They have not heard? Mr Speaker, they should go and check the records.

Mr Speaker, I think that those of us in public office must learn to at least respect the trust that the citizens have reposed in us. If we will not multiply their assets, let us not steal what they have given to us to guard and I am so proud of President John Dramani Mahama that within weeks of being in office, the first issue he seeks to tackle is the issue of the looting of public lands. I think that it is an opportunity for us in this House, as Members of Parliament, to follow his footsteps and to ensure that we also track the process that he himself has put in place to hold each other accountable so that every regime that comes will steadfastly hold the previous regime accountable. I hear people talk about the political class. I hate the notion that as a political class, we should conspire to loot property, to be corrupt and divest the state of its assets. Mr Speaker, the people voted us to protect those assets and we must be seen doing that.

Let me thank the maker of the Statement. I can assure him that the process President John Dramani

Mahama has put in place will be a transparent and open process. If public land needs to be sold, we should declare and explain why that public land needs to be sold and if public land needs to be sold, the sales should be transparent. It should be through auctions so that the highest bidder will bid for it. So that the state can get the best value out of the sale of those properties. It is not the case that we should never sell state property, but when we are selling, let us make sure that the state gets the best out of it.

Mr Speaker, on that note, let me thank the maker of the Statement and assure him that the Minister will soon present the report to this House, our people say that, we will get to know the full length of the toad.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, do we bring Statements to a close?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, there is an Order Paper *Addendum* and —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I will come to you. I think Hon Sosu wants to raise an issue.

Mr Sosu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise under order 93(1) to seek your indulgence and with the leave of the House, to raise a matter of urgent public importance. Something that happened in

Madina Constituency that I want to bring to the attention of the House, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, he just said he wants to make a Statement of urgent public importance. What is it about? We do not know anything. So, definitely, we cannot entertain it. But let us listen to the Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, before the Statement, if the Minister can just lay the Reports of two of his Bills and we can free him to get back to work. Just to lay the Reports so that tomorrow we will take them.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Ayariga: Then after that we can take the Statement.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Chairman can lay the Papers.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, let me invite you to the Order Paper *Addendum* — Presentation of Papers. Let me invite the Chairman of Committee on Education to do the House the honours in laying the Papers.

PAPERS

By the Chairman of the Committee —

Report of the Committee on Education on the University for Development Studies Bill, 2025.

Report of the Joint Committee on Education, and Public Administration and State Interest on the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Papers have been duly presented. I direct that these Papers are distributed to Hon Members.

Mr Sosu: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Matthew Nyindam?

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I have seen the Statements my Hon Colleague wants to make. Yes, there is a Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But I thought it is in respect of the Paper that was laid.

Mr Nyindam: No, that has been laid. But this one is talking about urgent Statements and he comes under 93(1) and Mr Speaker, it is a very important Statement. I will not speak against the Statement; it is a good Statement. But to come under an Urgent Statement, Mr Speaker, let us not hide under some rules and set some precedence in this House that tomorrow will look as if we are choosing and picking.

This is the Statement, Mr Speaker, Statement by Hon Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu. Madina MP on a report of alleged defilement of a 14-year-old girl by 18 men in Madina.

6.53 p.m.

This is the Statement, Mr Speaker, Statement by Hon Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu. Madina MP on a report of alleged defilement of a 14-year-old girl by 18 men in Madina. This is the Statement. So, the issue is as crucial as we all must condemn. But it should come under a normal Statement, so we can all contribute. But if he comes under urgent Statement—I do not see how urgent this Statement is.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, he discussed with me. In actual fact, I did not even know that it has been put on paper. I thought it was so urgent that he was going just to speak to it. So, I have already granted him the—Yes, so, Hon Sosu, just speak to it without necessarily reading the Statement.

STATEMENTS

Defilement of a 14-Year-Old Girl by 18 Men in Madina

Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC — Madina): Mr Speaker, my attention has been drawn to media reports on the alleged defilement of a 13-year-old girl who has been gang-raped by 20 men, leaving her traumatised and pregnant. Mr Speaker, that was a report that has been going around on all news portals.

Mr Speaker, my checks with the Madina Divisional Domestic Violence and Victim Support Unit (DOVVSU) Commander of the Ghana Police Service confirms the facts of the story as follows. One, the victim in question is actually 14 years and lives in Madina. Two, the girl

was discovered pregnant by her parents. Three, upon questioning, she said she had had sexual intercourse with 18 men on different occasions. The Madina Divisional DOVVSU has obtained a statement of complainant from parents of the victim. The statement of the victim has also been obtained. A police medical report form was issued in this respect to the complainant to send the victim to the hospital for examination and report. Two suspects have been apprehended, cautioned and detained to assist the police investigation. Efforts are underway to get the remaining suspects arrested since the condition is a matter of defilement.

Mr Speaker, upon receiving the news and the briefing from the Divisional Police Commander and as someone who has been interested in fighting for the rights of children in this country, I have offered myself, together with a team of lawyers, to hold criminal watching brief for and on behalf of this victim.

Mr Speaker, this Statement is so crucial because we are talking about a minor defiled by 18 people. Mr Speaker, we cannot consider a statement like this to just wash away because it is something we should be able to condemn. Mr Speaker, beyond that, I have already worked with the Medical Director of Pantang Hospital to provide psychological support for the victim.

Mr Speaker, I thank you so much for giving me the opportunity to bring this matter to the fore because when you go to Madina today, this is a major issue and parents are worried about their children.

They do not know the future of their children.

Mr Speaker, I want to assure the people of Madina and the parents that whatever we will do to bring these perpetrators to book, that is what we are going to do as their representative in Parliament.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I want to strongly advise that we leave his Statement as it is because if you look at the contents, as discussed by the maker of the Statement, it is a pure criminal matter. Further comment on this issue—Because Police will still investigate. He said he is putting up a team of lawyers and other things, so I do not think it is something that we should be commenting on.

He has made the Statement as a Member, so let us leave it as it is and his team of lawyers to support the girl in question, so that we do not debate much on this issue.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. No comment.

Yes, Hon Member—I just want to from where the Minority Whip—

Ms Millicent Yeboah Amankwah (NDC — Sunyani West): Mr Speaker,

thank you for the opportunity to comment on the—No, comment on the reference that was made by the First Deputy Minority Whip.

Mr Speaker, indeed, I side with him, but, as a female Member of Parliament, I would want to commend my Colleague for this Statement. We also know clearly that it is a criminal issue, but we would need to add our voice to the fact that parents should be much concerned about the whereabouts of their children before they get themselves into this matter and it become a huge issue in society. I know the situation of the young child and what she might be going through as of now in the community. We side with them. We will commend the maker of the Statement but urge the DOVVSU to take this matter up. These things have been happening in other constituencies, but it is a matter that has come to the Floor and Members of Parliament will follow up on these issues to make sure justice prevails.

Thank you for the opportunity.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Members, I am not—It is all right.

Hon Members, she was just complementing what the Minority—No, the First Deputy Minority Whip raised a

fundamental issue and I think we have to take it on board.

Hon Members, we bring Statement time to a close. We thank all the makers of the Statements and those who also contributed to the Statements that have been read today.

Leadership, any indication?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I move that we adjourn until tomorrow, 2 o'clock in the afternoon.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, a Motion has been moved for adjournment and that Motion has been seconded.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, why? I have not adjourned the House, but why are you all on your feet?

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 6.39 p.m. till Tuesday, 15th July, 2025 at 2.00 p.m.

